Are Women's Wings Barriers to Women's Political Advancement?

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Abstract

Women's wings exist in 40 percent of parties worldwide, yet are uncorrelated with the share of women parties nominate. Why do women's wings enable women's political entry but not their political advancement? Using data from an original survey and conjoint experiment with 1,054 elites from two of the India's largest parties, I find that party elites' promotion preferences overlap with the sociopolitical capital that women's wing leaders lack. Evidence from the survey and 106 elite interviews show that an intentional organizational division of labor confines women's wing members to vote and crowd mobilization, away from consequential party work and decision-making. Unable to develop the sociopolitical capital elites prioritize in promotions and candidate selection, women's wing members are more likely to be passed over for promotion and candidacy than their peers in the party organization. The paper highlights that ostensibly egalitarian institutions can entrench male elite power by creating parallel, unequal career tracks that exclude women from centers of political power.

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Introduction

Political parties around the world have increasingly institutionalized women's inclusion through the creation of women's party organizations, such as women's wings, caucuses, and associations. Today, nearly 40 percent of parties formally recognize such an organization within their statutes (Pruysers, Cross, Gauja, and Rahat 2017; Scarrow, Webb, and Poguntke 2022). Women's party organizations, which I refer to as women's wings, are a critical pathway for women to join political parties, often offering a gender norm-conforming mode of political engagement (Chowdhury 2026; Tajali 2022). Yet, there appears to be no correlation between the presence of a women's wing and the share of women nominated as candidates by a party, across electoral systems and party types.[1] It is puzzling that women's wings do not seem to facilitate women's advancement into positions of partisan power, despite their stated purpose of increasing the descriptive and substantive representation of women.[2] Why are women's wings unable to generate meaningful pathways into party leadership and candidacy, despite bringing women into the partisan fold?

Recent work on gender and party politics does not fully explain the puzzle posed by women's wings. Scholars of gender and politics have examined political parties—their composition, recruitment and selection strategy, level of centralization, and electoral outcomes—as barriers to women's political representation (Caul 1999; Crowder-Meyer 2013; Fox and Lawless 2010; O'Brien 2015). Simultaneously, a growing literature on party organizations has examined the importance of formal leadership positions in the party and their consequences for internal party promotions, electoral candidacy, progressive ambition, and intra-party democracy (Allie, Mahajan, and Verma 2026; Auerbach and

[1] See Appendix A.

[2] For example, the world's largest political party, India's Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP), describes its women's wing as a vehicle for creating "equal opportunities for social, political and economic growth" (BJP 2025). The constitution of the women's wing of Tanzania's Chama Cha Mapinduzi describes itself as an institution "building women's political, social and economic capacity" (UWT 2017, p.iii). The Australian Labor Party's 2015 constitution describes the National Labor Women's Network's role as one "encourag[ing] women to join and participate in the Australian Labor Party," running "training programs to improve the skills, confidence and participation of Labor women," and promoting women "within branches and other structures of the ALP as well as to elected office," among others (ALP 2015, p.14).

Thachil 2023). Both literatures alone are limited in their explanatory power. On one hand, gender and politics research pays less attention to how party organizations are structured and formal leadership positions are delegated within the party. On the other, scholarship on party politics does not explicitly examine whether the positions and sub-organizations in the party are equally important for a politician's career advancement and whether these roles and institutions are gendered.

A critical examination of women's wings requires both perspectives. Scholars of gender and politics have long called for examining parties as gendered institutions that (re)produce gendered hierarchies of power and affect women's political careers (Kenny 2007; Kenny and Verge 2016; Mackay, Kenny, and Chappell 2010). A gendered approach to studying institutions is necessary, with recent empirical scholarship highlighting the limits of institutional reform in transforming women's political representation and participation (Auerbach and Ziegfeld 2020; Chauchard, Brulé, and Heinze 2025; Heinze, Brulé, and Chauchard 2025). Indeed, formal institutions constitute only one half of the story; informal institutions—such as networks and norms—can mitigate or amplify the positive impacts of formal institutional reform (Heinze 2025; Jensenius 2016; Prillaman 2023; Purohit 2026).

In this paper, I bring a gendered perspective to the study of party organizations to offer an explanation for the paradox of inclusion posed by women's wings. I argue that parties create women's wings primarily to mobilize women voters, not to act as incubators of political leadership, despite stated goals of expanding descriptive and substantive representation of women. Though women's wings offer women an opportunity to join the party, an organizational division of labor silos its members out of consequential party work and decision-making. As a result, women's wing members are unable to develop the sociopolitical capital that elites prioritize during promotions and candidacy and, thus, experience low rates of organizational mobility and electoral candidacy. The theory, therefore, describes the uneven distribution of political power and authority across sub-organizations of a political party—the main party organization and party wings—that enables women's political entry but not their advancement, and allows male party elites

to maintain dominance in the party organization.

Using a mixed-methods approach, I provide evidence for the theory from India, home to some of the largest political parties and women's wings in the world. Quantitatively, I draw on data from an original in-person survey that featured an embedded forced-choice conjoint experiment. Through sustained fieldwork and trust-building with party officials, I secured rare access to a population that remains difficult to survey. The survey was administered to 1,054 post-holding political elites from two of India's largest parties, the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) and the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP). The survey captures novel measures of politicians' career trajectories, decision-making, and ambition, allowing me to present descriptive and causal evidence for limited intra-party mobility for women's wing members. I supplement the data with qualitative insights from 106 in-depth interviews with politicians and political consultants conducted between 2023 and 2026 in India, as well as observations from the Delhi state-election campaign in 2025.

I begin by providing causal evidence for the traits that party elites prioritize during internal party promotions, for instance a ward or district committee president or vice-president. Through a forced-choice conjoint experiment administered to over 1,000 party elites, I find that service delivery, mobilization capacity, financial contributions, previous party leadership experience, and party loyalty are strong determinants of who is promoted to partisan leadership roles. The descriptive survey evidence corroborates the causal findings and adds party networks as an important trait in the selection of main party organization leaders. I then show that women's wing members in the survey are less likely to possess these networks and sociopolitical capital relative to women leaders in the main party organization. This key finding highlights the *institutional* disparity among women party elites located in different sub-organizations of the party.

I describe organizational division of labor as the primary mechanism underlying these results. Using qualitative and descriptive survey evidence, I show that women's wing members occupy different roles and perform different labor in the party relative to women in the main party organization and men in other party wings, such as youth and student wings. Using career trajectories and reported promotions, I show strong descriptive

evidence that women's wing members are nearly half as likely to receive lateral promotions into the main party organization and opportunities for electoral candidacy, relative to their peers in the party organization. This limited organizational mobility persists even after controlling for pre-political entry networks (which can determine selection into the women's wing), tenure in the party, and politician caste.

Taken together, these results show that women's wings are a paradox of inclusion by design. They allow parties to bring women into the partisan fold and strategically use them to mobilize women voters. But precisely this role assigned to women's wings in the party organization also allows party elites, often male, to exclude women's wing members from the center of decision-making—the main party organization—while claiming gender-inclusiveness in party ranks.

These findings make three key contributions to the research on gender, institutions, and party politics. First, the paper highlights that ostensibly gender-egalitarian institutions can reinforce, instead of rupturing, inequalities. As seen with gender quotas, institutions alone cannot facilitate women's political representation (Amar, Bamezai, and Kumar 2025; Heinze et al. 2025; Thomas, Hankla, Banerjee, and Banerjee 2024). They require concurrent transformations in elite behavior and structural conditions (Heinze 2025). In the case of gender quotas, cooptation by male elites prevents women from exercising meaningful political power. In this paper, I demonstrate that women's wings fail to advance women's political careers because the uneven distribution of power is institutionalized within the party organization itself. The structure and distribution of political power within the party organization can affect internal party promotions and candidacy and thus, explain why women are absent from top party leadership and elected positions (Barnes and O'Brien 2025; Smith, Cirone, Teele, Cox, and Fiva 2026).

Second, the paper makes a key empirical contribution. It provides data from difficult-to-access actors—party elites—who are simultaneously aspirants for promotions and gatekeepers of promotions for others. Much of the gap in understanding organizational hierarchy exists because access to selection committees where promotion decisions are made is immensely difficult for party outsiders. By surveying party elites who are decision

makers, I join recent empirical work that opens the black box of how parties select who advances, becomes a candidate, and joins the rank and file (Auerbach and Thachil 2023; Gatto and Radojevic 2025; Gulzar, Hai, and Paudel 2021; Gulzar, Pathak, Thompson, and Tóth 2024). Comprehensive data on career trajectories, political experiences, political ambition, and promotion preferences allows me to paint a holistic picture of (a) how elites experience party gatekeeping themselves and (b) how they contribute to this gatekeeping based on their own gender and political identities.

Third, it sheds light on a potential source of positive change—the women's wings themselves. Existing literature shows that women's wings do facilitate women's political entry and help advocate for the career advancement of some women (Goyal 2026). This work also acknowledges that women's wings create gendered enclaves within the party organization. I take this claim seriously and interrogate the causes and consequences of this phenomenon. While women's wings hold enormous potential for transforming women's political inclusion, the current equilibrium suggests that the benefits of inclusion only apply to a select few women. The challenge arises in transforming the roles assigned to women's wing members, facilitating transitions into the main party organization, and conferring the benefits of inclusion on all women, not simply the elite and networked. Any effort towards meaningful political inclusion and power for all women will require interventions addressing these challenges.

Previous Work on Party Organizations and Women's Political Advancement

Political parties are gatekeepers to women's political entry and advancement. Scholars have argued that parties are less likely to recruit women into politics, resulting in gender gaps within party ranks (Crowder-Meyer 2013; Fox and Lawless 2010; Norris and Lovenduski 1994).[3] Party elites who make decisions about electoral candidacy and party leadership can also keep party women out of positions of authority or deliberately assign

[3]Recent empirical work has shown that intentional efforts to recruit rank and file party members can diversify party composition (Gulzar et al. 2024).

them to losing seats during elections (Bjarnegård and Zetterberg 2019; Folke and Rickne 2016; Kenny and Verge 2016; Martínez i Coma and Lago 2022). Some work has also assessed the organizational features of parties—level of centralization in decision-making, presence of women's organizations, and share of women leaders in selection committees—that enable women's political representation (Caul 1999; Kittilson 2011).

Meanwhile, a related literature has begun to unpack the black box of party organizations. Scholars are emphasizing the importance of informal and formal leadership positions in the party organization, describing how these leaders are selected by citizens and party elites (Auerbach and Thachil 2018,2). They also highlight the profound implications of formal positions in the party for internal promotions, electoral candidacy, intra-party democracy, and the progressive ambition of party elites (Allie et al. 2026; Auerbach and Thachil 2023).

Read separately, these literatures have limited explanatory power in unpacking the puzzle posed by women's wings. Work on gender and party politics offers valuable insights into how parties contribute to gender gaps in women's political presence and representation. But it is yet to consider the structure of the party organization and distribution of political power within it, and intra-party promotions or formal leadership positions in the party as key explanatory and outcome variables, respectively. Simultaneously, as a growing field, work on formal positions in party organizations is yet to examine gender as a key dimension shaping who holds power and who advances in the party organization. Moreover, while acknowledging that formal positions exacerbate hierarchies in the party that already rely on informal networks (Allie et al. 2026), this work does not analyze whether power is equally distributed across positions and institutions within the party organization.

A study of women's wings requires theoretical insights from both literatures. It mandates extending the role of parties as gatekeepers beyond electoral candidacy to include internal party promotions. At the same time, it requires a disaggregation of the party organization into its component sub-organizations, analyzing how power is distributed across these sub-organizations and relationships between each constituent part. Most

critically, it necessitates viewing the party organization as a gendered institution that (re)produces gendered hierarchies of power and processes of exclusion (Kenny 2007; Kenny and Verge 2016; Mackay et al. 2010). Recent work on gender and political institutions, both formal and informal, underscores the importance of combining these perspectives and shows that the transformative potential of formal institutions is often blunted by elite cooptation, rigid gender norms, and homosocial networks (Amar et al. 2025; Brule, Chauchard, and Heinze 2022; Chauchard et al. 2025; Heinze 2025; Jensenius 2016; Karekurve-Ramachandra and Sood 2024; Purohit 2026).

In what follows, I offer a gendered theory of organizational mobility and distribution of power within a party organization to explain why women's wings have become the primary pathway for women's political entry but not their advancement. The theory was derived inductively through over seven months of fieldwork conducted in Delhi, India.

Parties and Women's Wings: The Paradox of Inclusion

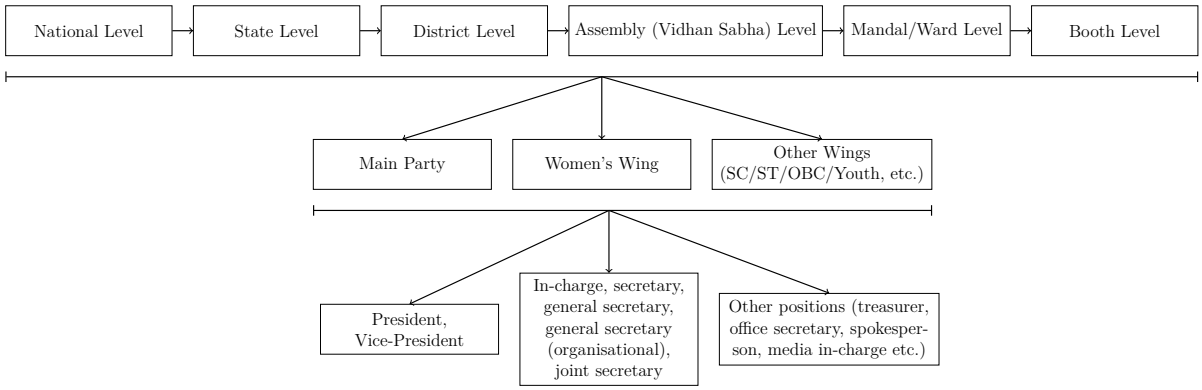
I argue that women's wings allow political parties to include women without disrupting male elite dominance in the party organization. Women's wings are not incubators for political leadership, and by circumscribing them to a limited role and function within the organization, parties prevent women's wing members from developing the networks and sociopolitical capital that elites prioritize during promotions and electoral candidacy.

I begin by discussing the structure of party organizations in India and how leaders are selected within them. Political parties in India comprise rank-and-file members, appointed post-holding leaders (or party elites), and elected representatives. While the strength and density of the organization vary across parties and across time for a single party (Chhibber, Jensenius, and Suryanarayan 2014), it typically spans multiple administrative levels and has several wings.

Figure 1 shows a simplified version of the most expansive party organization structure for a national political party. In the top row are the various administrative levels of the

party organization, organized by geographic units. Within each of these committees, the party is divided into the main party organization and its wings. These wings are usually either identity- (such as gender or caste) or occupation-based (such as trade or farmers' wing). The main party organization is the central decision-making authority, while the party wings report to and execute directives from the parent body. In each wing at each administrative level, the party appoints leaders, who make up the third row in Figure 1. Elected politicians—at the ward, state, and national level—can be understood as being situated above the president at the corresponding administrative level. This is because candidacy and being elected are often the goal for many politicians and a key function of the party apparatus is to get candidates elected. This vertical and lateral party structure is not unique to Indian political parties; parties across the world have identity-based sub-organizations and territorial units beyond the national (Ammassari, McDonnell, Bolin, Werner, Valbruzzi, Wegscheider, Heinisch, and Jungar 2026; Pruysers et al. 2017; Scarrow, Webb, and Poguntke 2017).

Figure 1: Party Organization Structure: Hierarchy, Wings, and Positions



Party elites, who are predominantly men, determine organizational mobility for party members.[4] They select leaders and candidates who can help them win elections. Certain traits—what I call sociopolitical capital—make individuals more favorable for promotions and candidacy. Prior experimental and descriptive work has shown that elites prefer electoral candidates who can deliver services to constituents and mobilize voters

[4]Male dominance in politics is not a phenomenon specific to India. Across the world, men are overrepresented in all aspects of politics, including electoral and non-electoral politics (World Bank 2026, UN Women 2025).

for the party; have previous leadership positions in the party organization, longer tenure in the party, and financial resources; and can demonstrate party loyalty (Auerbach and Thachil 2023; Bjarnegård and Kenny 2015; Bussell 2018; Chaudhury 2022; Clayton and Zetterberg 2021; Singh 2023). Networks can mediate much of this sociopolitical capital. Who you know in the political ecosystem can affect not only whether you can get work done for voters, but also whether you can join a party, be promoted in its ranks, become a candidate, and garner votes as a candidate (see, for instance, Bjarnegård and Kenny 2016; Piscopo 2016, for a discussion of gender, networks, and candidate selection). While existing work has shown causal relationships between this sociopolitical capital and candidate and broker selection, I theorize that similar traits determine intra-party promotion to formal leadership positions as well.

The traits prioritized in promotion decisions may disadvantage women in two ways. First, this sociopolitical capital is inherently gendered in that women are less likely to possess it, particularly in patriarchal societies. Women (in politics and beyond) tend to be more financially constrained and have more women-centric networks, less procedural knowledge and experience delivering services and goods to voters, and modest experience with decision-making (Auerbach, Singh, and Thachil 2024; Daby 2021; Sarkar 2024; Singh 2023).

Second, it may disadvantage a particular group of women in the party—those located in the women's wings. Women who come from political families or are embedded in elite partisan networks are less likely to face these constraints and more likely to get leadership positions within the main party organization. Indeed, the prevalence of women politicians who belong to political dynasties in India corroborates this claim (Basu 2016; Jensenius 2019). Women's wing leaders, on the other hand, may find themselves in the wing precisely because they do not have elite networks that can place them in the main party organization. But critically, I argue that the institution itself contributes to the capital differences among women's wing members and main party organization women. This is because of an intentional organizational division of labor that occurs within the political party, siloing women's wing members out of consequential party work.

What role do women's wings serve in women's political careers and the party organization? Women's wings offer a pathway into partisan life for a majority of women. Women politicians and activists are more likely to recruit other women into politics, particularly through women's wings (Goyal 2026; Tajali 2022). They provide a space where women can be involved in politics and work for the party, often framed as service, alongside other women (Bedi 2017; Chowdhury 2026). Several women politicians I interviewed suggested joining the women's wings of parties as the first step to entering politics. Because the main party organization and other party wings are dominated by men, women's wings become a gender-norm conforming pathway into the party. A politician's daughter, a bureaucrat herself, said, "It is easier to convince your family if you say you will join the women's wing of a party."[5] A male leader in one political party emphasized that "women's wings should exist because that's a soft entry. At least they are entering [through the wing]."[6]

For the political party, women's wings serve as an institution of strategic inclusion (Valdini 2019). Despite claiming in party statutes that these wings intend to advance women in politics, they largely exist to mobilize women voters for the party. In practice, this means that women's wing members perform two key functions for the party organization. First, their primary role is to reach women voters; their gender allows them to breach the boundary between the life inside the household and political life outside (Goyal 2024b). Second, they assist the party with crowd mobilization: organizing protests related to women's issues and attending rallies and events where the party values visibly large crowds as symbols of strength.

Women's wing members, however, are not included in consequential party work and decisions. The party's organization structure and distribution of decision-making power within it make it so that women's wings occupy a second-tier status relative to the main party organization. Women's wing leaders effectively report to their main party counterparts, instead of making autonomous decisions about their internal functioning (See, for instance, the constitution of the BJP 2012). Consequential decisions during and

[5]Interview Subject 7, interviewed by author on January 11, 2024, in Delhi, India.
[6]Interview Subject 52, interviewed by author on November 15, 2025, in California, USA.

outside of election time are made within the main party organization and relayed to the women's wing. When candidates are chosen during elections, elites in the main party have a greater say in formation of lists than leaders in the wing (Sarkar 2024). One senior leader of the INC specifically said that decisions surrounding candidacy were taken by leaders in the main party organization and were completely separate from her mandate as a women's wing leader.[7] Women's wing members are rarely included in planning campaign strategy, leadership selection (even for their own wing leaders), or policy decision-making. Party leaders themselves recognize this pattern of limited inclusion. In an interview, a former AIMC President, Sushmita Dev, observed,

> "I keep thinking of ways to initiate integration...I suggest the Youth Congress to conduct women empowerment programmes such that we can join them. I tell the parent body that we are hosting a programme and we want our top male leaders to attend it. Sometimes by creating different compartments one tends to isolate women and it becomes that much easy to perpetuate gender discrimination. The idea is to put everybody in one pool and say "now work it out for yourselves." If somebody has worked in my Frontal Organisation, I make sure that if they have worked diligently they get promoted to the parent body. So, they see the organisation as a stepping stone, a softer platform to get into the mainstream party. Unless we change the perception of women's organisations, we will just end up being a separate compartment that has nothing to do with the rest of the party" (Chhibber and Shah 2020).

How does this division of labor translate into gaps in sociopolitical capital? Arguably, the most critical gap arises in women's political networks. Women's wing members are embedded within female-centric networks, among both voters and politicians. Even though mobilization capacity is highly valued by party elites, assigning women's wing members to women's vote mobilization mechanically shifts the gender composition of their constituents. In a similar vein, in the limited instances when women's wing members do aid their constituents in accessing public goods and services, the constituents are

[7] Interview Subject 90, interviewed by author on August 5, 2026, in Delhi, India.

likely women. Previous ethnographic work on clientelism in Argentina by Mariela Daby highlights that female brokers accrue smaller networks and are less able to benefit from their networks due to gender differences in political work (Daby 2021). These findings map onto female party workers in women's wings, whose networks are not only smaller, but are also more homogeneous and reduce their ability to capitalize on political benefits of clientelism. Unlike men, or even women in the main party organization, women's wing members contend with dual gatekeeping: women higher up in the women's wing and members of the main party organization, who are primarily men. Women's wing members' access to the main party organization is moderated by their own senior female leaders, who themselves are competing for lateral and vertical promotions.

Networks can then affect other sociopolitical capital necessary for promotions. Crowdfunding or fundraising is often the only alternative for financially constrained women whose political ambition may not be supported by the household. But crowdfunding requires connections to wealthy individuals who will support her campaign, and these individuals are mostly men. Similarly, delivering services requires close connections to bureaucrats or local elected officials. In the absence of such connections women's wing members must reach out to fellow politicians, who can then claim credit for service delivery, even if the request was facilitated by the women's wing member. In sum, women's wings limit their members experience with every aspect of politicking—developing networks, serving voters, strategic planning, decision-making, and policy formulation. If receiving a formal position in the party is a result of these skills and gains from holding formal positions accrue over time, then women's wing members experience compounding disadvantages over their career. Previous work on gendered division of labor in the party has highlighted its consequences for women's career advancement in other political institutions across the globe, such as judiciaries, cabinets, and ministries (Baekgaard and Kjaer 2012; Boulaziz 2027; Krook and O'Brien 2012; Taflaga and Kerby 2020) .

Because women's wing members likely lack the sociopolitical capital necessary for advancement in the party, I expect that they experience lower organizational mobility and electoral candidacy relative to both women in the main party organization and men

in party wings. The lower organizational mobility for women's wing members manifests in three distinct ways. First, women's wing members are seldom promoted into the main party organization, akin to a "glass wall," which I discuss in detail in the next section. Much like the proverbial glass ceiling where women can see male counterparts climbing to the top, women's wing members can see members of the main party organization on the other side of the horizontal divide progressing in their careers. Women politicians recognize the difference in prestige and importance of the main party versus the women's wing. For instance, a member of the All India Mahila Congress (women's wing of the Indian National Congress) said, "Women need to be active in the main party not just the Mahila Congress. They need to work in the block, district… learn through that experience."[8] When asked why women would want roles in the main party organization, a male senior leader in the Aam Aadmi Party said,

> "You know why this happens, it's because women can see that all the decisions are happening in the main wing, they are running the show so they want to be closer to the group that is running the show. Which means, the whole process is not inclusive enough to account for women. You are dangling the prize in front of them but giving them small gifts... I will think I want the prize [position in the main party]. When this happens, it creates a sense of superiority in their mind that people in the main wing are superior to us, we are inferior and it is important for us to go there."[9]

Second, women's wing members experience less upward mobility within the wing itself. There is less organizational churn inside the women's wing, meaning that members remain in their positions for longer tenures and are promoted to higher ranks (e.g., moving from secretary to president) or administrative levels (e.g., ward to district level) less often. Limited upward mobility within the wing is consequential because women in the upper echelons of the women's wing are more likely to interact with leaders in the main party organization and be included in decision-making. Third, because formal

[8]Interview Subject 20, interviewed by author on August 5, 2024, in New Delhi, India.
[9]Interview Subject 52, interviewed by author on November 15, 2025, in California, USA.

positions in the party are an important consideration in candidacy decisions for elites (Auerbach and Thachil 2023), lack of promotion to party leadership roles has enduring negative consequences for women's wing members' electoral candidacy (Curtin, Kerby, and Dowding 2023; Goodwin, Bates, and McKay 2021; Taflaga and Kerby 2020).

Therefore, women's wings become a paradox of inclusion by design—they enable women's entry into parties, but not their advancement into leadership or candidacy, which remains dominated by male elites. Parties strategically use women's wings to mobilize female voters, all while limiting their role in consequential decision-making and their presence in structures of power. This strategic and limited inclusion prevents women from creating diverse networks of important elites and developing the skills and traits valued by elites during promotion and candidacy decisions.

Strategic Inclusion Does Not Apply To Other Party Wings

The organizational division of labor should theoretically affect the promotion and candidacy opportunities of other party wing members (Jalali, Silva, and Costa 2024; Stockemer and Anlar 2024), who are largely men. On paper, their roles and responsibilities are similar to those of women's wings. They are expected to mobilize voters, represent the interests of their groups, and bridge representation gaps between citizens and parties for their identity groups. However, there are three reasons why members of other party wings may still experience higher levels of organizational mobility relative to women's wing members. First, homosocial networks help men maintain dominance in politics (Bjarnegård 2013). Even when men join a political party via a party wing, homosocial ties allow them to cut across party wings to form relationships with male elites in the male party organization. Therefore, despite occupying a less important position in the party structure, party wings' members can negotiate relevance through their informal ties to male elites in the main party organization (Jalali et al. 2024).

Second, despite a similar organizational mandate as women's wings, male-dominated party wings often act as stepping stones towards leadership in the main party organization, allowing men to maintain dominance within the party organization. Speaking of

men in the youth and student wings of the party, a party leader said,

> "They are, you know, considered as a natural hire to the district post, natural hire to the state post. You know, you have just served your time in [the student wing], what will you do next? You will join the [youth wing]. You served your time in [the youth wing], you become the general secretary, now you become the district vice president. This is the natural progression that is not available to women, strangely."[10]

Relating this back to the organizational division of labor, this variation may arise because party wings, other than women's wings, bestow advantages unique to them upon their members. Student wing members can participate in electoral politics at the university-level. They are able to gain the political experience that makes them valuable to a party—campaigning, setting agendas, mobilizing voters, and even running for office.[11] In one Indian party, youth wings select their leaders through internal elections, but the same process does not apply to leadership selection in the women's wing, where the appointment occurs top-down. Members of caste-based wings may experience further mobility because caste remains a salient factor in assessing "winnability" of candidates and in the vote mobilization calculus for a party (Singh 2023).

Third, exacerbating these dynamics may be overt taste-based or statistical discrimination against women politicians. Although gender bias is hard to detect empirically, qualitative evidence suggests the bias is present among male party leaders. Expressing frustration over women's exclusion from positions of power despite their significant presence in the party, a female party leader said,

> "There are a lot of women in the sangathan [organization] and in morchas [wings]. In the day to day, women are not included in the decision-making, strategic planning. Women are not seen as equals to men, unless they are

[10]Interview Subject 12, re-interviewed on January 26, 2026 (remotely). Lightly edited for clarity.

[11]Several prominent women politicians in India—Rekha Gupta (Delhi Chief Minister, BJP), Alka Lamba (National Women's Wing President, INC), Sushma Swaraj (former External Affairs Minister, BJP), and Mamata Banerjee (former West Bengal Chief Minister, TMC), to name a few—emerged from student politics. Recent empirical work suggests that women in party youth wings express greater political ambition and efficacy compared to men (Ammassari et al. 2026).

> related to a political family or someone of note. The problem is with men, not the party—they make women do all the work but then never make them the face of the party or the leader of the party."[12]

When asked if all party wing members face similar disadvantages in organizational mobility, a senior male leader replied, "Yes, but women will have more in every wing. The disadvantage is layered. One layer is you are not in main wing. Another biggest layer is if you are women. Otherwise everything is the same. There is a woman repellent mindset."[13] A key test for the difference between women's wing members and members of other party wings is comparing lateral promotion outcomes for the two groups. I expect that women's wing members will experience lower lateral promotions into the main party organization relative to male members of other party wings.

In sum, I argue that women's wings simultaneously enable women's political entry but limit their political advancement within the party because of an organizational division of labor. This strategic and limited inclusion occurs by design, allowing parties to include women without disrupting gendered hierarchies of power within the party organization. Members of the women's wing are tasked with mobilizing the women's vote or protesting on women's issues, leaving consequential decision-making, strategic planning, and service delivery to individuals in the main party organization. This division of labor leaves women's wing members unable to develop the necessary networks and sociopolitical capital that party elites prioritize in promotion and candidacy decisions. As a result, women's wing members experience fewer promotions into the main party organization, fewer promotions to higher positions within the wing itself, and lower rates of electoral candidacy. I am not the first to suggest that women's party organizations can silo women away from centers of power (Fernandes and Ranjan 2021; Kittilson 2011; Sanga, Demzee, Mosha, and Kihaka 2026). Rather, I build on this work to shed light on precisely how party organizations structure and distribute power across their sub-organizations to create these gendered silos and their consequences for women's political advancement and

[12]Interview Subject 24, interviewed by author on August 13, 2024, in Uttar Pradesh, India. Lightly edited for clarity.

[13]Interview Subject 52, interviewed by author on November 15, 2025, in California, USA.

representation.

Empirical Context

I situate the study in Delhi, India's capital, which has an estimated population of 23 million—as large as Switzerland, Finland, Norway, and Denmark combined. It is an urban metropolitan city with multi-party competition at the local and state level. Three main political parties compete for power in Delhi during municipal, state, and national elections: Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP), Aam Aadmi Party (AAP), and the Indian National Congress (INC). Since 2015, BJP and AAP have been the dominant players in all three elections, leaving INC without any seats in the state legislature or in the parliament from the state. In February 2025, BJP replaced AAP as the ruling party during the state election. AAP is the main opposition party in the legislature. For this reason, survey data collected focused on party leaders from only these two parties, while qualitative evidence is drawn from all three parties.[14]

In a broader weakly-institutionalized party system in India (Jensenius and Suryanarayan 2022), BJP and AAP represent two different types of parties. BJP is best characterized as a right-wing mass-mobilization party, rooted in religious nationalism (Gunther and Diamond 2003). AAP started off as a movement-based party, born out of an anti-corruption social movement. It is now best understood as a personalistic electoralist party (Gunther and Diamond 2003), with its political orientation in recent years described as "soft Hindutva" or right-of-center (Nath 2025). BJP has a thicker and more expansive organization structure and is considered more bureaucratic in its promotion and candidacy practices than AAP. Variation in party age and type allows me to assess how the theory applies to different types of political parties. BJP, AAP, and INC all have well-established women's wings, though the degree of institutionalization of the wing in the party hierarchy varies. Party documents and websites suggest that all three parties set up women's wings as a way to mobilize the female electorate, while simultaneously

[14]In addition to its diminished political relevance in the state, it was difficult to map the organizational structure and party leaders situated within the INC beyond senior leadership during fieldwork.

describing these women's wings as sites of women's political inclusion in the party. I provide further detail on the formation of women's wings in the three parties in Appendix B.

Research Design

Conjoint Experiment With Party Elites

The primary evidence for the organizational mobility theory, the sociopolitical gaps between women's wing members and main party organization women, and the promotion outcomes comes from an original elite survey with an embedded conjoint experiment. I surveyed 1,054 post-holding party leaders from BJP and AAP in Delhi, prioritizing breadth across administrative levels, party wings, and positions.[15] Of these, 554 were from AAP (421 men and 133 women) and 500 were from BJP (297 men and 203 women). Respondents were surveyed by enumerators either at their party offices or their homes, and each survey lasted approximately 35 minutes.[16] The survey was fielded in-person between August and October 2025.

The survey sample is a convenience, snowball-sample; initial names and contacts of party leaders were obtained by establishing relationships with senior party officials during fieldwork.[17] Table 1 provides a descriptive summary of the sample. The sample characteristics reflect that political elites tend to come from more privileged backgrounds compared to the broader population and align with demographic backgrounds of local politicians surveyed in previous work (Auerbach and Thachil 2023; Goyal 2024a,2). My

[15]In Delhi, there are approximately 250 ward committees, 70 assembly level committees, 11 district committees, and one state level committee. Given difficulties of surveying elites at scale, I pool results across elites from different administrative levels. As (Kertzer and Renshon 2022) report, there is little evidence of heterogeneity in results across types of elites, making pooled samples the appropriate method to deal with the small-N problem when surveying elites.

[16]The survey locations are based on the geolocation of the data submitted by enumerators. In rare instances, respondents' survey locations may not correspond to the ward where they hold a leadership position. Based on the geolocations, at least half of Delhi's wards were covered in the survey.

[17]The initial strategy involved a random sample of wards and their corresponding district/assembly-level committees and an attempt to create complete party lists from all selected committees through establishing Memorandum of Understanding (MOU) agreements. This approach, however, ran into many obstacles as top party officials did not want their names on any written agreements. Moreover, many claimed to either not have complete party lists or refused to share them with party outsiders, even with signed agreements of confidentiality.

Table 1: Descriptive Statistics of Survey Respondents (N = 1054)

Variables	Mean	SD	Min	Max
Gender (Female = 1)	0.32	0.47	0	1
Age	46.20	11.05	19	83
General Caste (Yes = 1)	0.53	0.50	0	1
OBC (Yes = 1)	0.24	0.43	0	1
SC/ST (Yes = 1)	0.22	0.42	0	1
Hindu (Yes = 1)	0.91	0.29	0	1
Muslim (Yes = 1)	0.06	0.24	0	1
Married (Yes = 1)	0.90	0.30	0	1
10th Pass or Below (Yes = 1)	0.20	0.40	0	1
12th Pass (Yes = 1)	0.29	0.45	0	1
BA/Diploma or Higher (Yes = 1)	0.51	0.50	0	1
Employed (Yes = 1)	0.80	0.40	0	1
Asset Index	0.83	0.15	0	1
AAP (Yes = 1)	0.53	0.50	0	1
BJP (Yes = 1)	0.47	0.50	0	1

Notes: Caste variables are computed for the 1032 respondents who reported a caste category. The Asset Index is the share of 11 household assets a respondent owns (range 0–1).

survey oversampled female elites to ensure that I was well-powered to estimate heterogeneous effects by gender in the conjoint experiment and estimate differences among women from different sub-organizations in the party. Further details on the survey sites and sample composition can be found in Appendix C.

I present causal evidence for the organizational mobility theory using a forced-choice conjoint experiment administered to all respondents in the sample. The conjoint experiment asked each party elite to choose one profile from a pair of hypothetical candidates for internal promotion to an organizational leadership role within their party (either the president of the ward committee or the president of a district committee). Each respondent performed the selection task four times. Candidate profiles randomly varied across eight ethnographically- and empirically-grounded dimensions: gender, caste, mobilization power, electoral campaign contributions, ability to deliver services to constituents, previous leadership experience in the party, party membership history, and political networks. Appendix F describes the operationalization of each variable and an example vignette.

Following the standard conjoint estimation strategy (Hainmueller, Hopkins, and Ya-

mamoto 2014), I present the Average Marginal Component Effect (AMCE) when reporting the estimates for the binary promotion outcome. For the AMCE, I use the fully non-parametric linear regression estimator presented in Hainmueller et al. (2014), and cluster the standard errors derived from the estimation at the respondent level. When presenting heterogeneous treatment effects (for respondent gender and party and candidate gender), I use Average Marginal Means (AMM) (Leeper, Hobolt, and Tilley 2020). I conduct three tests of heterogeneity. I assess the differences in outcomes based on the respondent's gender and party. I also assess heterogeneous effects based on the hypothetical candidate's gender, effectively interacting gender with all other attributes. For all three, the appropriate estimand is the AMM, so that results are not sensitive to the withheld baseline (Leeper et al. 2020). These are included in Appendix H.

Descriptive Survey Measures

In addition to the conjoint experiment, party elites were asked a battery of descriptive questions about their demographic background, and political career trajectories, capital, networks, and ambition. Responses to these questions were used to create measures for 1) first leadership position in the party, 2) promotion outcomes, 3) pre-entry networks for each respondent, and 4) sociopolitical capital for each respondent. I describe each sequentially.

Each respondent was asked their first, current, highest, and all other leadership positions in the party, disaggregated by position (e.g. president, vice-president, secretary, etc.), administrative level (e.g. ward, district, state, etc.), and sub-organization (main party organization, women's wing, or any other party wing) for each position they listed. The list of formal positions in the party for each respondent allowed me to construct the first leadership position and three distinct measures of promotion. To assess whether they had been promoted laterally to the main party organization, applicable to only those whose first position was in a party wing, I created a binary measure that recorded if they had *ever* held a leadership position in the main party, regardless of administrative level or position. Similarly, to assess whether they had been promoted upwards either in position

(for e.g. from a secretary to a vice-president) or in administrative rank (for e.g. from the ward to the district level) within the sub-organization their leadership careers started in, I created a binary measure that recorded if they had *ever* been promoted in position or administrative level within the sub-organization of their first leadership position.[18] The electoral candidacy outcome is a binary measure based on the elites' response to whether they have ever contested an election at any level: student, local, state, or national.

Pre-entry networks of party elites are measured by two variables. The first records whether the individual who encouraged the respondent to join politics is a man. The second is a binary variable for whether the respondent has family in politics.[19] I construct the sociopolitical capital for each respondent using their responses to questions about their networks in the party, their perceived recognition in their constituency, their previous leadership experience in the party, and expressed loyalty to their party. Detailed descriptions of each variable are included in Appendix G.

To test for gaps in sociopolitical capital between women's wing members and women in the main party organization, I performed Chi-squared and t-tests on the standardized difference between the two groups. I test differences in women's pre-entry networks and promotion outcomes among members of party wings and the main party organization using adjusted and unadjusted ordinary least squares (OLS) regressions, with robust standard errors. In covariate adjusted models for promotion outcomes, I use controls for pre-entry networks, number of years in the party (to measure tenure), and the caste of the respondent.

Qualitative Evidence

I supplement the quantitative causal and descriptive results with qualitative insights from multiple rounds of fieldwork, conducted between December 2023 until August 2026

[18] Because the hierarchy of roles beyond an elected representative, and the president or vice-president of the party organization at any level is not clearly defined, I use a strict measure of position promotion that only records promotions from any other position to either elected, president, or vice-president as a position promotion.

[19] In Appendix J, in addition to the gender of the recruiter, I use two alternative measures for pre-entry networks: whether the respondent had connections in politics prior to joining and a combined measure of prior connections and family in politics. Results are not sensitive to the construction of pre-entry networks.

in Delhi, India. During this time, I held semi-structured in-depth interviews with 106 respondents, recruited through snowball sampling. These included student politicians, party workers and leaders, elected representatives, political strategists and consultants, and non-partisan political activists. Interviewees spanned several political parties and organizations, including the BJP, AAP, INC, Communist Party of India, and All India Trinamool Congress. I also observed the 2025 Delhi state election campaign, which involved attending door-to-door canvassing and press conferences of various parties. A list of all the individuals interviewed during fieldwork is included in Appendix D.

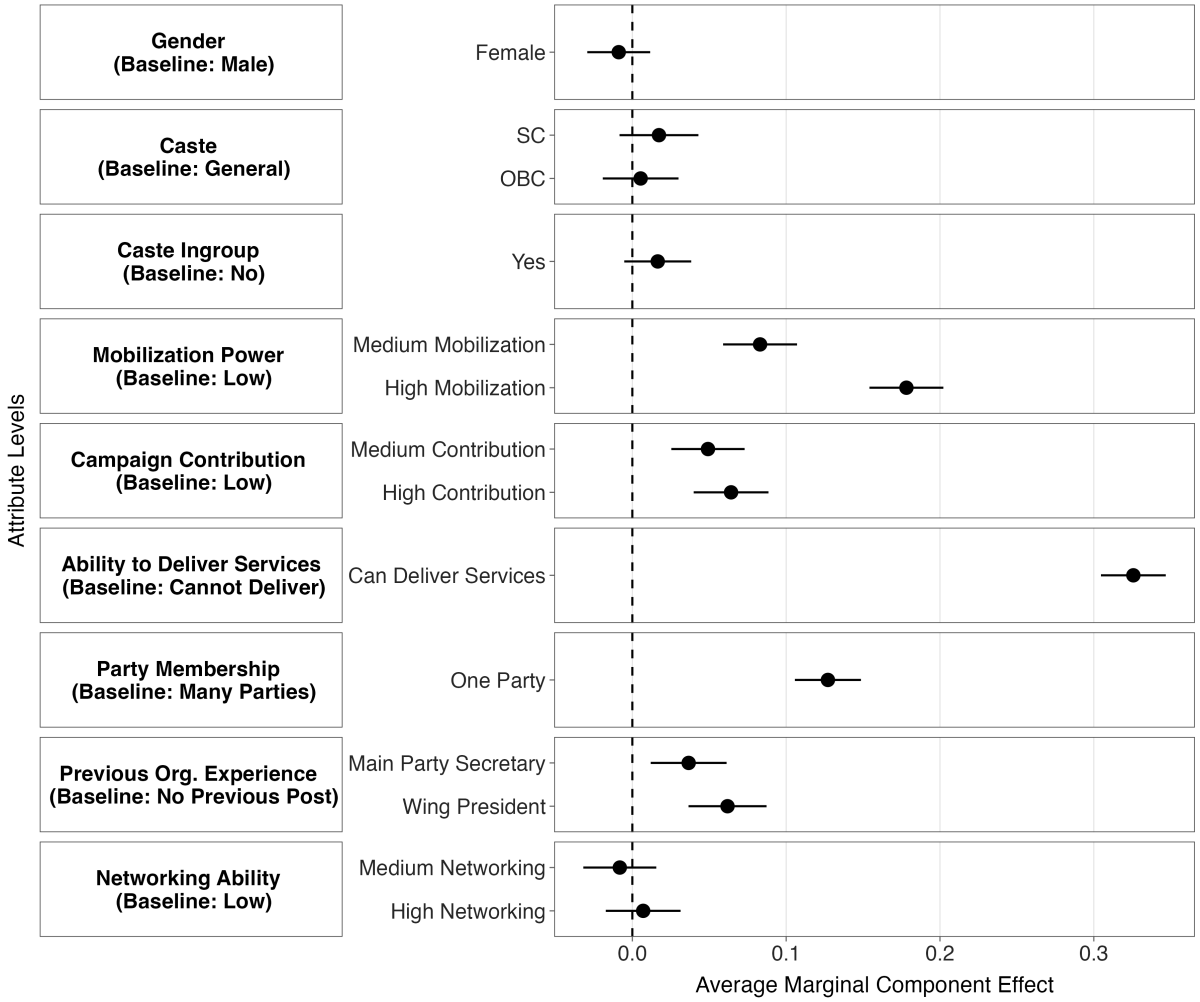
Results

I begin by discussing causal evidence for who is more likely to receive promotions in the party organization. I then show descriptive evidence, through survey measures of sociopolitical capital, that women's wing members lack precisely the skills and traits that elites prioritize during promotion decisions. Using qualitative insights and descriptive evidence from the survey, I show that a division of labor within the party organization contributes to this gap in sociopolitical capital; women's wings enable women's political entry and parties use them to mobilize voters, but silo them out of critical aspects of politicking that happen in the main party organization. Lastly, I provide evidence that women's wing members experience lower organizational mobility and electoral candidacy relative to men in party wings and women in the main party organization, despite high levels of political ambition.

Who do party elites promote within the party organization? To answer this, I turn to the conjoint experiment. I asked party elites to select a candidate, from two fully randomized hypothetical candidate profiles, that their party would choose as a ward or district committee president. Following Hainmueller et al. (2014), Figure 2 presents the Average Marginal Component Effects (AMCEs)—the marginal effect of an attribute averaged over the joint distribution of all other attributes—from the experiment.

I find that parties want to promote politicians who are good at all aspects of politick-

Figure 2: Effect of Candidate Attributes on Intra-Party Promotion



Note: This figure shows the estimated marginal effect of each attribute of a candidate on the probably of that candidate being chosen for promotion. The model estimates come from an OLS regression with robust standard errors, clustered at the respondent level. The bars represent 95% confidence intervals. Baseline categories are withheld and listed in parentheses for each attribute on the left-hand side.

ing: those who get work done for the voters and the party, can fund themselves, are loyal to the party, and can demonstrate leadership experience. Parties placed the greatest premium on candidates who could solve constituents' problems—getting streetlights fixed, garbage collected, or roads repaired. Relative to those who could not deliver services to their constituents, candidates who could were 32.5 percentage points more likely to be promoted (p-value < 0.01). The ability to get work done for voters has been shown as a critical aspect of developing local influence in politics and being a valuable foot soldier for a political party (Auerbach and Thachil 2023). Similarly, parties value politicians who can mobilize supporters for the party. Candidates who could organize medium (8.3 pp, p

< 0.01) and large (17.8 pp, $p < 0.01$) rallies were more likely to be promoted, both relative to those who could organize small rallies. During interviews, local level politicians would repeatedly describe "crowd mobilization" and adding members to the party as important facets of their job. A senior leader in a national party said that women's wing members were assigned leadership positions based on how many new women members they could bring into the party.[20]

Candidates' ability to fund their own campaigns is attractive to the party. Candidates who could contribute Rs. 1-5 lakh (4.9 pp, $p < 0.01$) and Rs. 5-10 lakh (6.4 pp, $p < 0.01$) to their election campaigns were more likely to be promoted, both relative to those who could contribute less than 1 lakh. In a landscape where election campaign costs continue to balloon and parties only have limited financial resources for candidates across elections, candidates' ability to self-finance is important to political parties (Bussell 2018; Luhnow 2024). Since formal leadership positions are a ladder towards candidacy, parties likely want to begin promoting individuals with money up the hierarchy.[21] Party elites also reward loyalty to the party. Candidates who were lifelong members of the same party were more likely to be promoted (12.7 pp, $p < 0.01$), relative to a candidate who had switched parties.

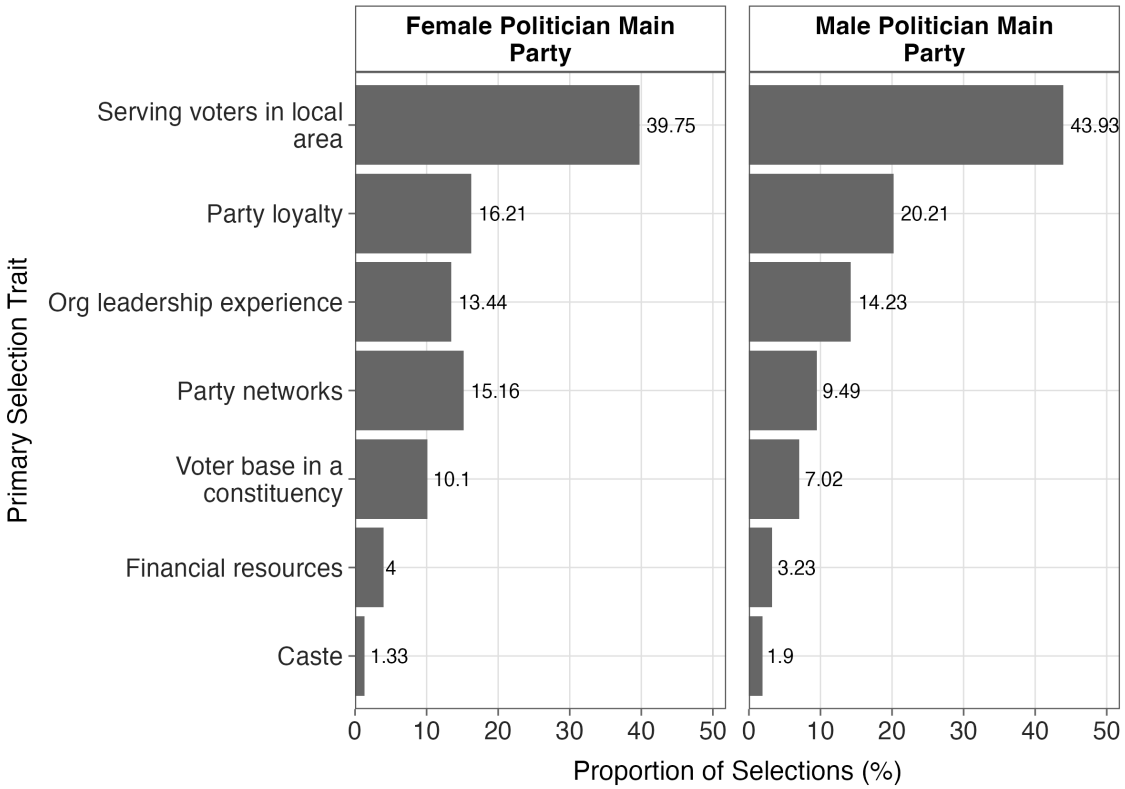
Lastly, the results show that formal leadership positions in the party organization accrue benefits. Candidate with previous leadership roles in the party were more likely to be promoted (between 3.6 and 6.1 pp, $p < 0.01$) than those who had never held a position. Previous work in the Indian context has shown that party brokers, particularly those with political ambition for candidacy, vie for formal positions in the party organization as stepping stones in their political careers (Auerbach and Thachil 2023). Unsurprisingly, leadership positions in the party have compounding benefits; what I show subsequently, however, is that not all positions bestow benefits equally to their recipients.

Though stronger networks are not predictive of promotion in the conjoint experi-

[20]Interview Subject 90, interviewed by author on August 5, 2026, in Delhi, India.

[21]While waiting to interview a party leader, I observed a conversation between them and a party member wherein the party member claimed she had to turn down a formal leadership position in the women's wing of her state because it required her to contribute upwards of Rs. 10 lakh (approximately $10,000) each month to the party.

Figure 3: Important Leadership Traits in the Main Party Organization



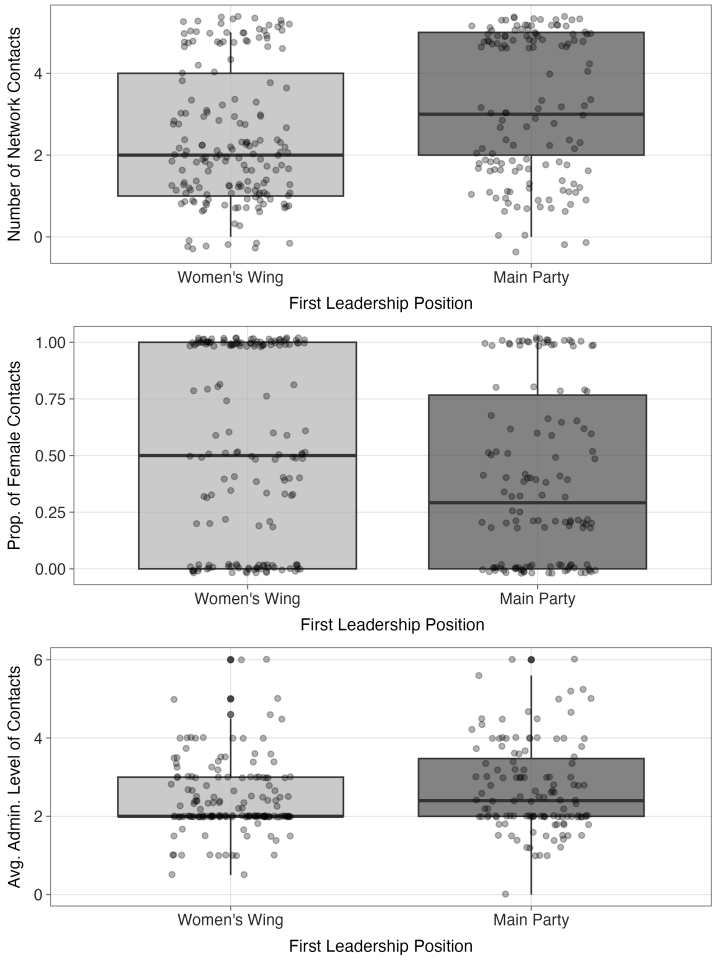
Note: The figure shows percentage of respondents who selected an attribute as the most important factor for becoming a female or male leader in the main party organization. Respondents could choose only one trait per question, so percentages sum up to 100.

ment, certain predictive attributes—organizational leadership roles held, recognition in a constituency resulting in mobilization power, and administrative networks that enable service delivery—are consequent benefits of having the right networks during one's political career. It is also plausible that respondents were not sensitive to differences in networks in the particular operationalization used in the conjoint. Because, when asked what is the most important factor party leaders consider in appointing leaders in the main party, respondents ranked party networks as the third and fourth most important factor for female and male leaders respectively. Figure 3 presents the descriptive survey evidence that corroborates the experimental findings.

In sum, the conjoint experiment and descriptive data highlight that organizational mobility is determined by several critical aspects of politicking. In what follows, I show that women whose leadership careers began in the women's wing are deficient in the very aspects that make them viable for promotions. I benchmark their sociopolitical capital

to women leaders in the main party organization as a way to "control" for gender and isolate the institutional impact of the wing.

Figure 4: Comparing Political Networks for Women's Wing and Main Party Organization Women

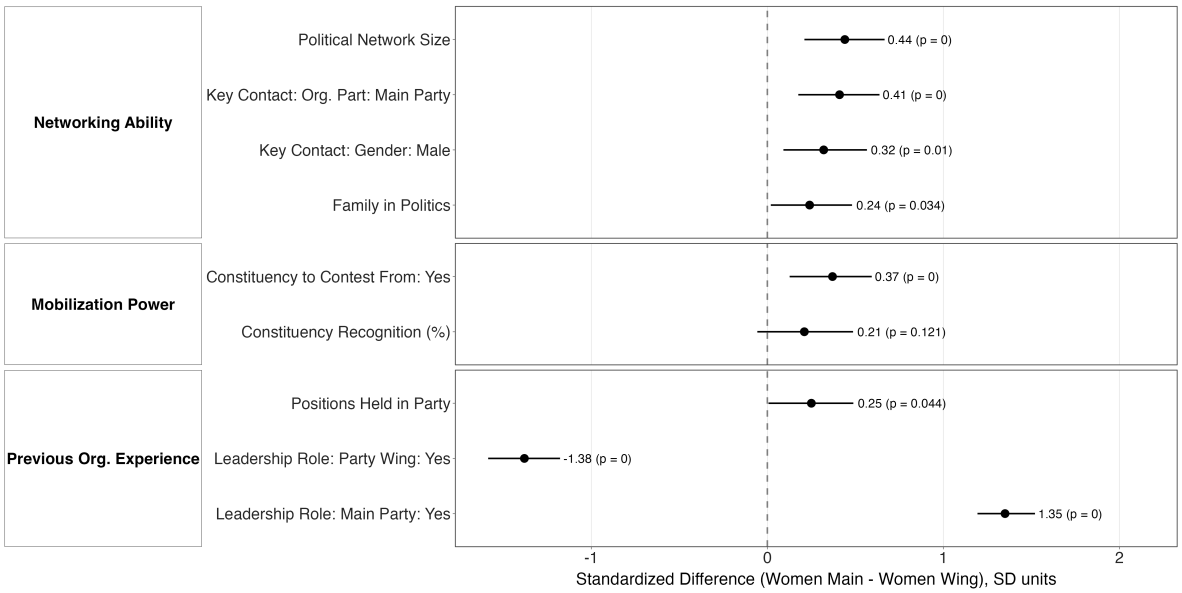


Note: The box plots show the distribution of and differences between the political networks of women's wing members and women in the main party organization. Each respondent was asked to name up to five people closest to them in their political network. The top panel is the distribution of number of network contacts named by each respondent. The middle panel is the distribution of the proportion of female contacts named by each respondent. The bottom panel is the distribution of the average administrative level (e.g. ward, district, state, etc.) of the contacts named by each respondent. A higher average indicates more contacts higher up in the party hierarchy.

Political networks of women's wing members are smaller, more female-centric, and less elite than those of main party women. Figure 4 shows differences in the size and quality of political networks between women's wing and main party organization women. The differences were estimated using elites' survey responses to name up to five of their closest contacts in the party. Disaggregated by their first leadership position within the party,

the figure shows that women's wing members, on average, name fewer close contacts, name more female close contacts, and name fewer close contacts who are higher up in the party hierarchy, compared to women leaders in the main party organization.

Figure 5: Sociopolitical Gaps between Women's Wing and Main Party Women



Note: This figure shows differences in sociopolitical capital between women whose leadership careers began in women's wing versus the main party organization. The measures were constructed using survey responses from elites about their political networks, if they had a constituency to contest elections from and what proportion of the constituency recognized them, their previous organizational leadership experience from reported formal leadership positions in the party, and expressions of party loyalty. The estimated differences (calculated using Chi-squared and t-tests) are differences in mean standardized units for each measure, with 95% confidence intervals.

Network gaps are reflected in who women's wing members name as their most important party contact in Figure 5. Overall, the size of their networks is smaller than that of main party women (0.44 SD, $p < 0.001$). They are 18 percentage points less likely to name a main party leader as their most important contact (0.41 SD, $p < 0.001$) and 16 percentage points less likely to name a male leader as their most important contact (0.32 SD, $p = 0.01$), compared to main party women. Women's wing members are also 11 percentage points less likely to say they have family in politics (0.24 SD, $p = 0.034$) relative to main party women. Because networks are seen as one of the most important factors for women to progress into main party leadership, women's wing members' qualitatively different networks are likely to produce disadvantages in the promotion process.

Figure 5 also reports other sociopolitical capital gaps between women's wing and main party women. Women's wing members are tasked with mobilizing female voters (Goyal 2026; Tajali 2022), limiting their sphere of influence in their own constituencies to a particular group. I see this reflected in whether women report having a constituency to contest an election from. Women's wing members are 17 percentage points less likely to report having a constituency to contest elections from (0.37 SD, $p < 0.001$). Though among women who report having a constituency, the difference in proportion of people who recognize them is not statistically significant, the gap between women's wing members and main party women still exists (3.2 pp, 0.21 SD). Not having a constituency to run from and lower recognition in a constituency are likely also a result of who main party women are connected to. For instance, main party women from locally-recognized political families or those embedded in the network of an influential local male politician are more likely to be recognized by constituents in their neighborhood.

In the conjoint, party elites are more likely to promote candidates with previous organizational leadership experience. Using the list of reported formal positions held in the party by respondents, I find that women's wing members, on average, hold fewer positions and that these positions are concentrated in the women's wing rather than the main party organization (bottom panel of Figure 5).[22] The divergence in types of positions held in the party between women's wing members and main party women is critical and central to the argument made in this paper. The main party organization is the locus of decision-making and authority in the party. The descriptive evidence presented here suggests that when a woman's leadership career begins in the main party organization (women's wing), these benefits (disadvantages) compound over time.

In Appendix I.1, I present suggestive evidence that differences in sociopolitical capital are not merely a product of factors that sort women into the women's wing or main party organization. I compare these capital gaps among women across the sub-organizations in the first four years of their party tenure to women 10-14 years into their tenure. I

[22]Mechanically, all women whose careers start in a sub-organization have held a formal leadership role in that institution. The key comparison in this figure, then, is that 32 percent women's wing members have held roles in the main party, while 39 percent main party women have held roles in a party wing.

find that sociopolitical capital gaps between women's wing and main party women late in their tenure are larger than the gaps between those early in their tenure. This evidence should be interpreted with caution because I compare two distinct sets of women in the main party and women's wing (as opposed to the same women in different institutions over time) and the sample sizes are small.

While women politicians across women's wings and the main party did not differ in their stated financial contributions to electoral campaigns, women's wing members were less likely to name their political party as the primary resource for financial help during an election campaign (21.6 percent compared to nearly 30 percent of main party women). They were also more likely to state 'Don't know' or 'Prefer not to say' as a response than main party women (32.2 percent compared to 21.4 percent, respectively). Collectively, these statistics indicate that women's wing members feel less inclined to view their party as a financial resource and are less likely to know who to reach out to for financial support in the event of an electoral campaign.

Taken together, the conjoint experiment and the descriptive survey evidence indicate that women's wing leaders lack the precise sociopolitical capital that party elites prioritize during promotion decisions. In the next section, I provide qualitative and descriptive evidence to show that these gaps emerge due to a strategic division of party labor and have detrimental consequences for women's career advancement. Women's wings allow women's political entry to support the party's goal of mobilizing female voters. However, women's wing members are rarely involved in the decision-making or planning that occurs in the main party organization. As a result, they experience limited organizational mobility in the party organization, allowing existing gendered and elite hierarchies of power to persist within the party.

Strategic Organizational Division of Labor and Its Political Consequences

Women's wings provide a pathway for women to join politics. In my survey sample, 51.7 percent of women leaders began their party leadership careers in the women's wings.[23] However, once women are in the party organization, they are siloed into roles that prevent them from developing the sociopolitical capital necessary for promotion decisions, as shown in the previous section.

The survey and qualitative interviews indicate that the primary role for women's wing members is crowd and vote mobilization. When asked to describe their party contributions (see Appendix I.3), women who had never held a main party position and those who had held at least one main party position reported similar shares of community- and electoral-mobilization tasks. These included vote mobilization, meeting constituents, organizing community events, and campaigning and managing media for a candidate. However, a greater share of women who had held at least one main party position reported performing administrative and strategic tasks compared to women who had only ever been women's wing leaders. These tasks included office work for the party, helping voters get voter identification cards, recruiting party members, developing campaign strategies, and overseeing candidate selection. Describing a similar, but even narrower, division of labor in the Indian National Congress, a leader stated, "Mahila Congress [women's wing of the INC] takes the forefront at the women related issues…otherwise the DCC [District Congress Committee] takes the lead…When you talk about political decision-making, they're not taken into consideration that much. They don't hold much authority."[24]

The relationship between the sub-organizations, assigned labor, and sociopolitical capital, particularly networks, was visible during my interactions with party leaders. While attending a campaign event for a political party on January 22, 2025, in Northwest

[23] 40 percent began in the main party organization and 8.8 percent in other party wings. Other estimates of women's presence in the main party organization are far lower (for instance, Goyal 2026, estimates only 6 percent of women in the main party organization are women), because they consider a more restricted set of organization roles. My sample includes a wider set beyond the president, vice-president, and secretary, and includes leaders across the entire administrative hierarchy in the state, from below the polling booth level to the state level.

[24] Interview Subject 12, re-interviewed on January 26, 2026 (remotely). Lightly edited for clarity.

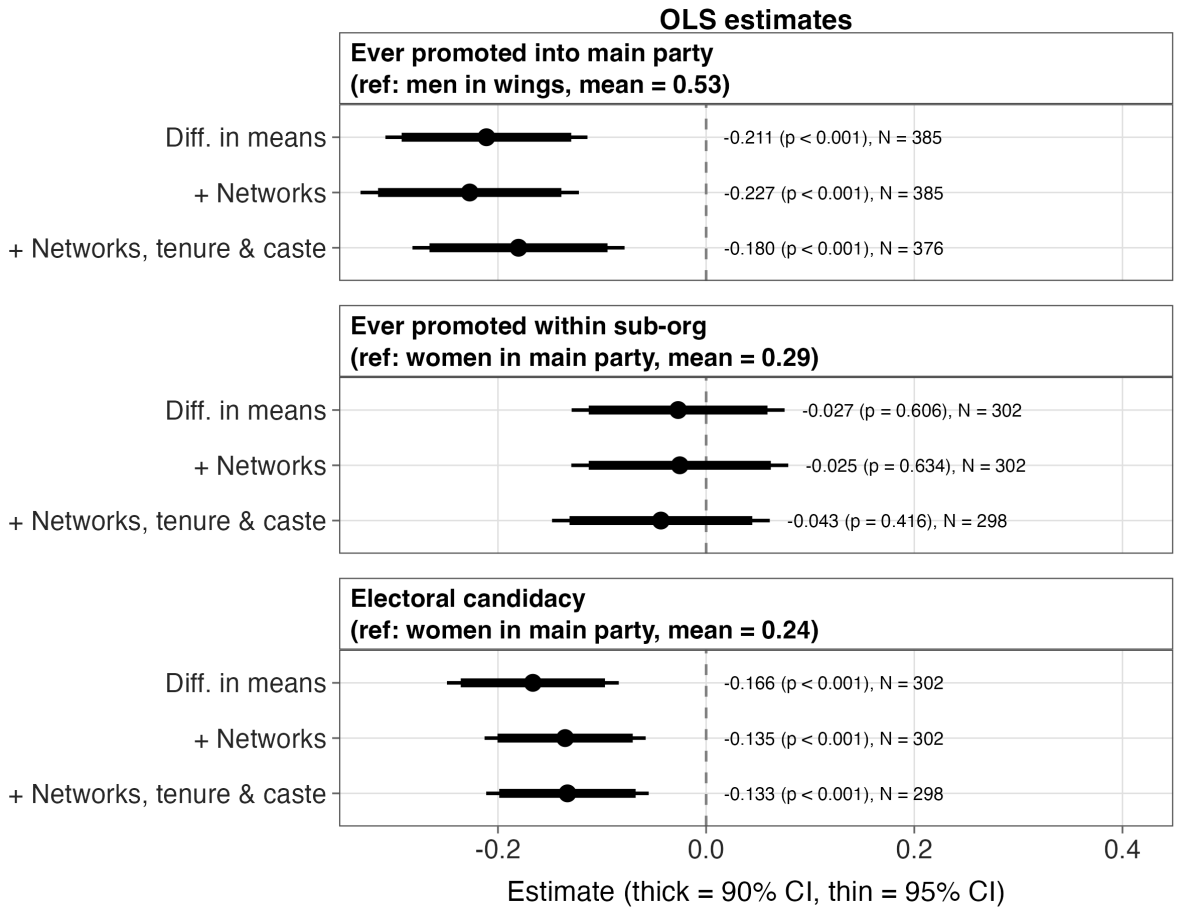
Delhi, I interviewed two women. The first woman, Asha, was the vice-president in the main party's district committee and the second woman, Jyoti, was the general secretary of the women's wing district committee.[25] Asha was pivotal to organizing the event and sat up front with the male leaders of the party, including the incumbent state legislator who was fighting for reelection. Jyoti, on the other hand, was merely an attendee and sat with other women leaders, several rows behind Asha and the male leaders. Later when I interviewed Asha, several male politicians walked through the office and spoke with her, clearly well acquainted with her. She spoke with authority over the work she did for the party and was confident she would one day be chosen as a candidate during elections. Jyoti, on the other hand, said "Not everyone gets a ticket, only one person [can], we can't get angry about it,'' settling for working for the party despite wanting more recognition for her efforts.

At the time of the survey, 46.3 percent of women respondents reported their current role as a women's wing leader, indicating low mobility out of the women's wing. By narrowing women's sphere of influence and their involvement in decision-making or everyday politics of the party, elites are able to prevent women's wing members' advancement in the party organization and maintain gendered and elite hierarchies of power.

I present three pieces of evidence for women's wing members limited career advancement in the party organization: lateral promotions into the main party organization, upward promotions in rank and administrative level in the women's wing, and electoral candidacy. Empirically, I benchmark women's wing members against men in other party wings (such as, youth and student wings) for lateral promotion, and against women in the main party organization for upward promotion and electoral candidacy. Because I have respondents' reported career histories, I can assess whether they have *ever* been promoted into the main party organization or upwards in the sub-organization where they started their party leadership careers. I show both unadjusted difference-in-means and covariate-adjusted estimates, where I control for respondents' pre-entry political networks, tenure in their party, and caste.

[25]Names changed for anonymity.

Figure 6: The Women's Wing Penalty in Promotion Outcomes



Note: The figure presents three models for each outcome: an unadjusted difference in means, an adjusted difference in means that controls for pre-entry networks, and an adjusted difference in means that controls for pre-entry networks, tenure in party, and caste. The outcome in the top panel is if the respondent has ever been promoted into the main party organization, the middle panel shows if they have ever been promoted within the sub-organization their leadership careers started in, and the bottom panel shows if they have ever been an electoral candidate. The top panel compares women's wing members to men in party wings. The middle and bottom panels compare women's wing members to women in the main party organization. All estimates come from OLS models with robust standard errors. The thick bars are 90% confidence intervals and thin bars are 95% confidence intervals.

Both unadjusted and adjusted models show clear evidence that women whose careers began in the women's wing are less likely to receive promotions into the main party organization compared to men whose careers started in other party wings (top panel of Figure 6). Women's wing members are 21.1 percentage points less likely to ever be promoted into the main party organization ($p < 0.001$), with estimates remaining robust even after controlling for pre-entry networks, time in the party, and caste. Pre-entry networks,

particularly a male recruiter into the party and family members in politics, are strongly predictive of whether women's careers begin in the main party or the women's wing (see Appendix I.5). Acknowledging that selection into a sub-organization is endogenous to promotion outcomes, here I show that it is not the entire story. Even though networks sort women into distinct institutions, being in the women's wing itself exacerbates barriers to their political advancement. Lack of mobility into the main party organization is damaging to women's careers because, as I discuss in previous sections, it is the locus of decision-making, authority, and, as I show subsequently, candidate-emergence.

Contrary to my expectations, women's wing leaders and women in the main party appear to receive similar rates of promotion within their sub-organization, in position (e.g. from treasurer to president) and rank (e.g. from ward to district). Between 25-30 percent of women leaders in both groups receive upward promotions in the sub-organizations where their careers start (middle panel in Figure 6). However, upon further examining promotion patterns, I find that instead of promoting women's wing members up the wing hierarchy, elites often transition women leaders in the main party to higher ranks and positions in the women's wing. This pattern of promotion is revealing in how male elites maintain their dominance in the party hierarchy (see Appendix Table I.6 for a summary of promotion patterns). Women's wing members receive limited promotions into the main party and to higher positions in the wing itself. Women leaders in the main party are moved over into higher positions in the women's wing instead of receiving vertical promotions in the main wing itself. Simultaneously, men in party wings transition into the main party at higher rates, while men already in the main party continue to progress up the ranks.

Lack of promotion to formal party positions has enduring negative consequences for women's wing members' electoral candidacy. Women's wing leaders are 16.6 percentage points (p-value < 0.001) less likely to become candidates compared to women leaders in the main party organization. The conjoint experiment shows that party elites value formal leadership roles in promotion decisions and previous work has shown that these leadership roles are valued by aspirants and the party in electoral candidacy (Auerbach

and Thachil 2023). Women's wing leaders, who hold fewer formal positions and fewer positions in the main party, consequently get fewer opportunities to become candidates for elections.

Cumulatively, these results show that though women's wings offer women a pathway *into* politics, they are not a pathway for women to *advance* in politics. Despite high levels of political ambition to advance in the party organization and towards electoral candidacy,[26] women's wing leaders are unable to do so. Party elites limit their responsibilities to vote and crowd mobilization, while gatekeeping access to central aspects of politicking. Unable to develop the sociopolitical capital they need to advance in the party, women's wing leaders remain siloed away from the main party organization. As a result, the prevailing gendered hierarchies of power continue to persist, while allowing elites to claim gender-inclusiveness in the party.

Conclusion

This paper is motivated by an empirical puzzle and a theoretical gap. Women's party organizations, such as women's wings, exist in nearly 40 percent of political parties across the world and are entirely uncorrelated with women's political representation (Scarrow et al. 2017). Existing work in political science is yet to systematically examine why parties create women's sub-organizations, their relationship to women's political representation, and why they may be failing to advance women's political careers. In this paper, I draw on existing theories of gender and party politics to propose an answer for why women's wings may be institutions of unfulfilled promise.

I argue that women's wings enable women's political entry, but effectively stymie their political advancement because they create a parallel and unequal career track for women in the party organization. Party elites create women's wings to bring women into the partisan fold as key mobilizers of the female vote. At the same time, they silo them out of party labor and decision-making that allows women's wing leaders to develop the

[26] In Appendix I.7, I show that women's wing members express high rates of political ambition, comparable to women in the main party organization and men across the party.

sociopolitical capital necessary for advancing in the party hierarchy and towards electoral candidacy. In limiting women's wing members' organizational mobility, party elites—who are overwhelmingly male—can continue to maintain their dominance in the organization.

Using novel conjoint, descriptive, and qualitative evidence, I find that women's wing members lack the precise sociopolitical capital that party elites prioritize during promotion decisions and is a result of an organizational division of labor. Relative to women leaders in the main party organization and men in other party wings, such as youth and student wings, women's wing leaders are less likely to receive promotions into the main party organization, upwards in the wing itself, and to become electoral candidates.

These findings suggest that interventions focused on women's wing leaders themselves may prove insufficient. On one hand, capacity-building trainings that teach women to fundraise or campaign can cover part of the deficit in their sociopolitical capital. On the other hand, this paper highlights that much of this sociopolitical capital is relational and conditional on how power is structured and distributed within the party. Given existing gendered hierarchies of power in parties and male elite bias against women politicians,[27] any intervention will require a multi-pronged approach. Buy-in from male elites in the party will be a necessary pre-condition for its success. Interventions will need to bridge network gaps and facilitate women's inclusion in decision-making and decentralization of power to the wing (such as, the ability to select their own leaders through an election or determine the wing's campaign strategy during an election), in addition to capacity-building as politicians.

My findings also imply that women's wing are necessary sub-organizations for women's inclusion. Existing work has highlighted the role that these organizations play in facilitating women's entry into party politics across the world (Goyal 2026; Tajali 2022). In the absence of women's wings, it is likely that women's political inclusion in parties would decrease substantially and be limited to those with connections to male party elites and representatives. At the same time, though women's presence in the party can have positive effects on women's representation (Caul 1999), this paper shows that these effects are

[27] In Appendix H.2, I show the gender bias present among male party elites and benchmark it against the lack of in-group caste bias.

limited in equilibrium. A vast majority of women who are able to join parties through these wings do not progress out of them into positions of genuine political power and authority. Therefore, the counterfactual is not political parties without women's wings, but rather political parties with women's wings that facilitate advancement beyond entry and are empowered institutions themselves.

The theoretical framework of the article also invites a third approach to studying political parties. The distribution of power within the party organization, as well as formal and informal rules dictating career advancement, necessitate the need to understand parties as both organizations and networks (Auerbach, Bussell, Chauchard, Jensenius, Nellis, Schneider, Sircar, Suryanarayan, Thachil, Vaishnav, Verma, and Ziegfeld 2022). The findings show us that party institutions, which structure the distribution of power, impact the networks that an individual can access and mobilize. Gendering the party organization—as feminist institutionalists suggest we do—validates the need for this approach.

Although the theory is drawn from two parties in India, it extends to contexts beyond the case and parties presented in the paper. When parties create top-down gender-inclusive institutions driven by strategic incentives, we can expect women's inclusion to come with limited political advancement. The theory likely applies to parties where centralized decision-making and informal rules dictate career advancement, particularly in low-information and patriarchal contexts across the Global South (Arriola, Phillips, and Rakner 2021; Phillips 2021; Wang and Muriaas 2019). In some cases, even when women's wings emerge bottom-up through grassroots movements, male dominance in the party can engender gaps between formal inclusion and meaningful career advancement (Sanga et al. 2026). Lastly, the patterns of career (im)mobility are fairly consistent across both the surveyed parties, though slightly are more pronounced in the AAP (see Appendix I.6) and suggest the theory may be broadly applicable across party types.

The paper invites future research into two key extensions of this work. First, a systematic comparative analysis of women's wings across electoral systems, countries, and party types may help us identify conditions that enable women's wings to be effective

institutions. Second, assessing other party sub-organizations—particularly youth and student wings—through a similar framework would provide additional insight into why some sub-organizations produce better political outcomes for women than the women's wing itself. Further examination of these questions will be critical for designing inclusionary institutions that effectively translate women's participation into meaningful inclusion.

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Appendix for

"Are Women's Wings Barriers to Women's Political Advancement?"

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A Women's Wings in Political Parties

Figure SI.1 shows the geographic distribution of countries where at least one party had a women's sub-organization. This is likely an undercount of the number of parties with women's wings since the database does not include many Asian and African countries, such as India, where many parties have an official sub-organization for women. Figure



Figure SI.1: Distribution of Women's Wings in Parties

SI.2 shows the lack of correlation between the presence of a women's wing in a political party and the share of women they nominate during an election. The lack of correlation

persists even when I look at countries with and without national-level gender quotas or reserved seats in Figure SI.3.

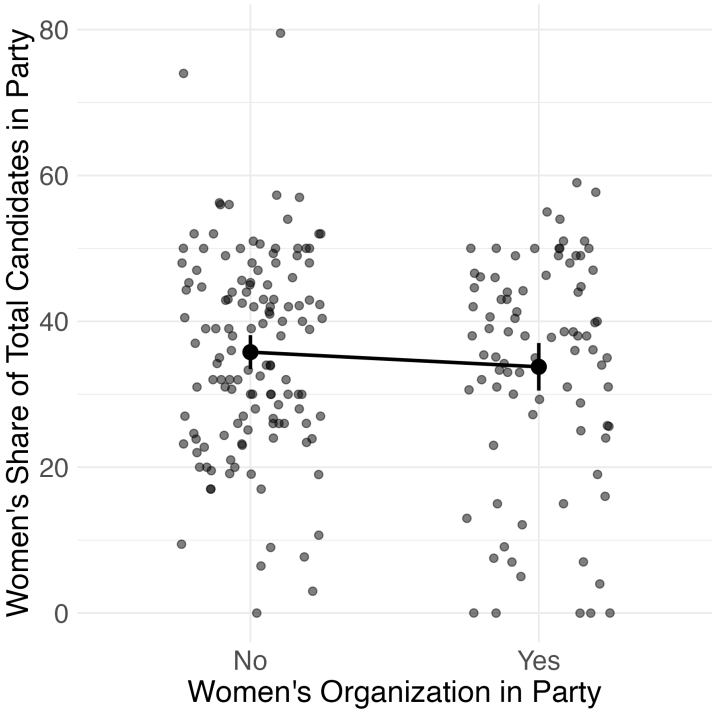


Figure SI.2: Correlation Between Women's Wing in Party and Share of Women Candidates in Party

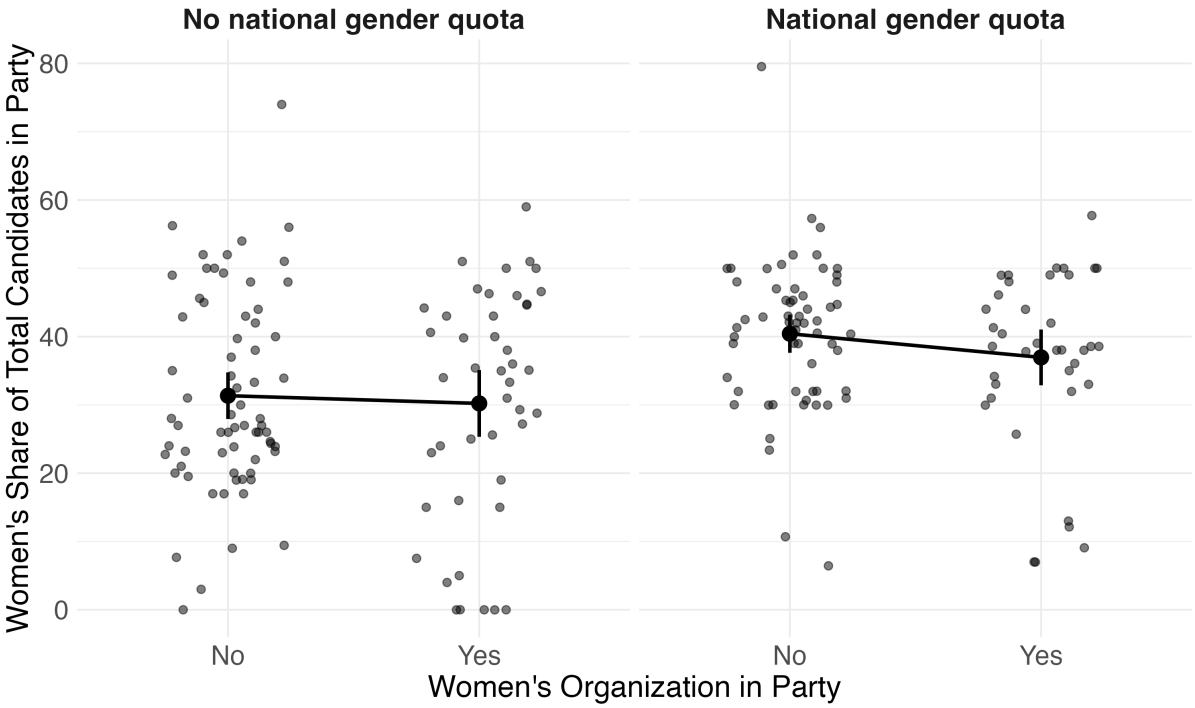


Figure SI.3: Correlation Between Women's Wing in Party and Share of Women Candidates in Party by National Quota Status

B Women's Wings in the BJP, AAP, and INC

Following significant electoral defeat in the 1984 national election, the BJP overhauled its party organization. It decided to broaden its electoral base to various minority groups and consequently, established various *morchas* (wings) and cells in the party (Kumar Malhotra and Jaitli 2006; Yadav and Patnaik 2022). These wings "articulated the problems of their respective fields, helped in policy formulation and in mobilising the field...also launched movements and agitations from time to time" (Kumar Malhotra and Jaitli 2006, p.22). The women's wing, or *mahila morcha*, was specifically meant to help "women participate in politics and work on women-related issues...ensure that women do not hesitate to join the political workspace" (Yadav and Patnaik 2022, p.50). Though each *morcha* would comprise members only of its own group, "they were not meant to compartmentalize the party but to create channels to let different groups of people into the BJP" (Yadav and Patnaik 2022, p.50). Today, the BJP *Mahila Morcha* targets the social, political, and economic development of women (BJP 2025) and spans the various administrative levels of the party organization.

The Aam Aadmi Party, on the other hand, has a less institutionalized women's wing. As a newer party established only in 2012, its party organization (and therefore, women's wing) is relatively thinner and more informal. For instance, the party constitution provides details on the broader organization structure of the party but it does not mention any party wings or their relationship to the main party organization (AAP 2021). However, fieldwork revealed a thicker party organization than its constitution suggests. Party leaders were appointed in the main party as well as the women's wing at the ward, district, state assembly constituency, national assembly constituency, and state level. In a press release in August 2025, the party signaled its intent to develop women's wing leaders (AAP 2025). However, other press releases suggest that the women's wing role is largely confined to mobilizing women voters and dealing with women-related issues.[1]

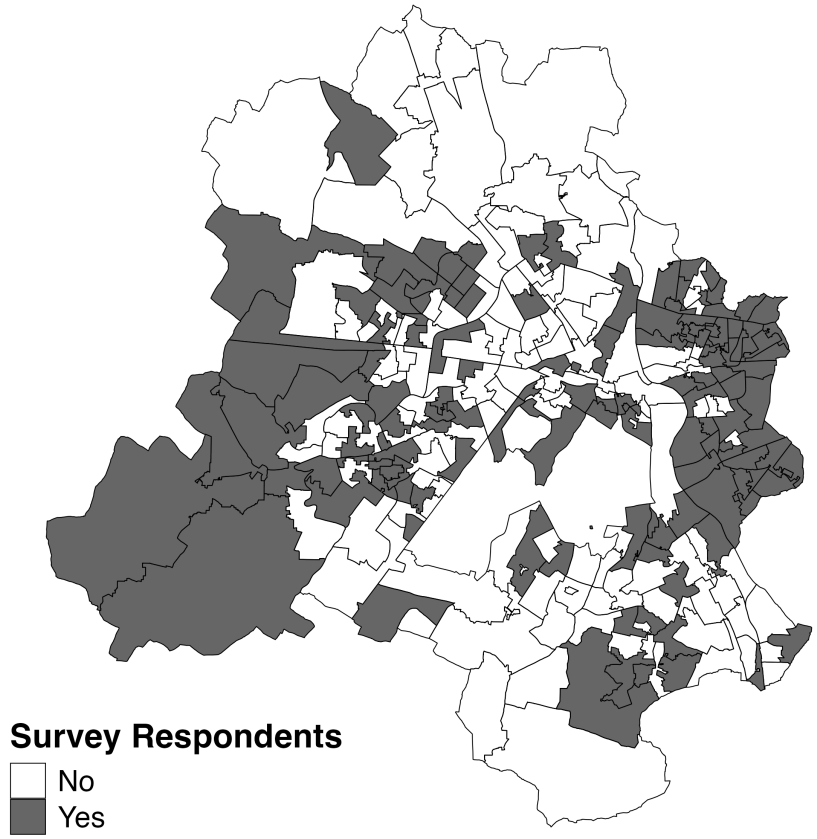
[1]For instance, AAP women's wing organized women's groups in Delhi during the state election to communicate the party's policy platform to women voters (AAP 2024). In another instance, AAP women's wing led protests against the assault of a Dalit woman in Punjab (AAP 2026). These are not isolated instances of what the women's wing for AAP does, but rather the norm described repeatedly by women interviewees in the party.

While not the empirical focus of this paper, the Indian National Congress's women's wing, *All India Mahila Congress* (AIMC), is one of the oldest among Indian parties. The AIMC was established as a frontal organization in 1983 and began functioning independently in 1984 (AIMC 2026). It has its roots in women's participation in India's independence movement and was established to "empower women and address their specific socio-political issues" and provide a "structured platform for women to engage in the political process, advocate for their rights, and influence policy decisions" (AIMC 2026). The wing's website states leadership development as one of its four core aims.

C Survey Sites and Sample Composition

Figure SI.4 shows wards where at least one individual was surveyed. 68 percent of the

Figure SI.4: Delhi wards with at least one survey respondent.



politicians surveyed were men. The average age of the politicians in the sample was 46. Slightly over half were from general castes, while the rest were split between Other Backward Castes (OBC) and Scheduled Castes/Scheduled Tribes (SC/ST). The sample is overwhelmingly Hindu, which is to be expected given the parties surveyed. Most respondents were married, half had at least a diploma or Bachelor's degree, and most were employed and scored high on the asset index. To construct the asset index, I asked respondents to state whether or not they owned/had each of the following assets and took the average: cycle, bike, car, TV, refrigerator, washing machine, computer, an electricity meter, water meter, land, and home. Figure SI.5 shows the sample composition by party, gender, and sub-organizations within the party. Figure SI.6 shows the composition of the survey sample by gender, party, administrative level of respondents' positions, and across

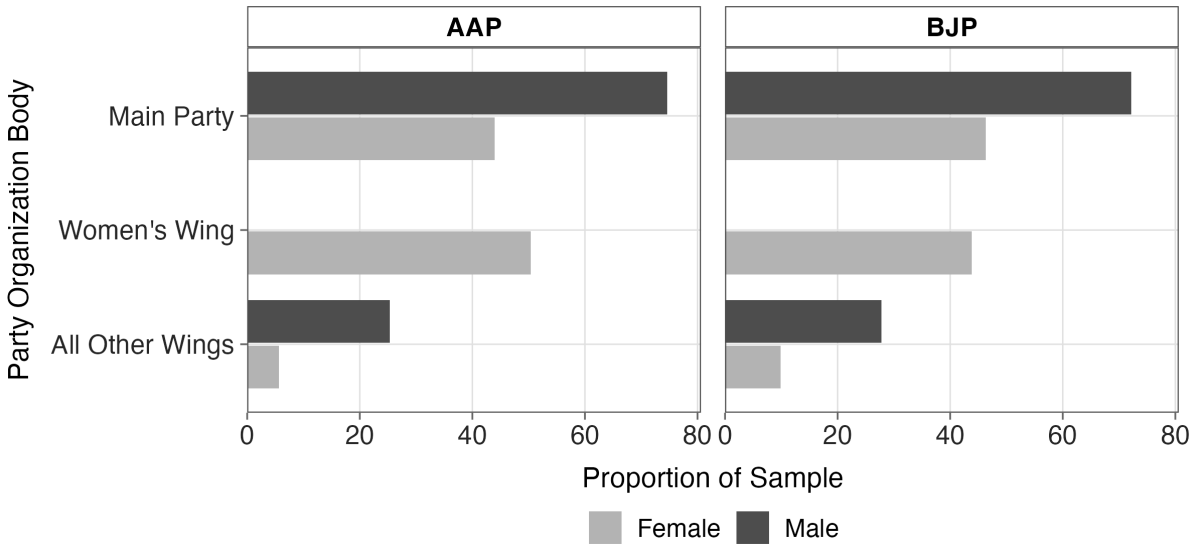


Figure SI.5: Survey Sample by Party, Gender, and Organization Part

the main party organization and other party wings, not including women's wings. Most respondents are located at the booth or ward level in both parties, across both genders. Figure SI.7 shows the sample composition by gender, party, and position within the party organization. All other positions includes a broad set of positions, ranging from secretary, joint secretary, and general secretary, to media in-charge, office in-charge, treasurer, etc.

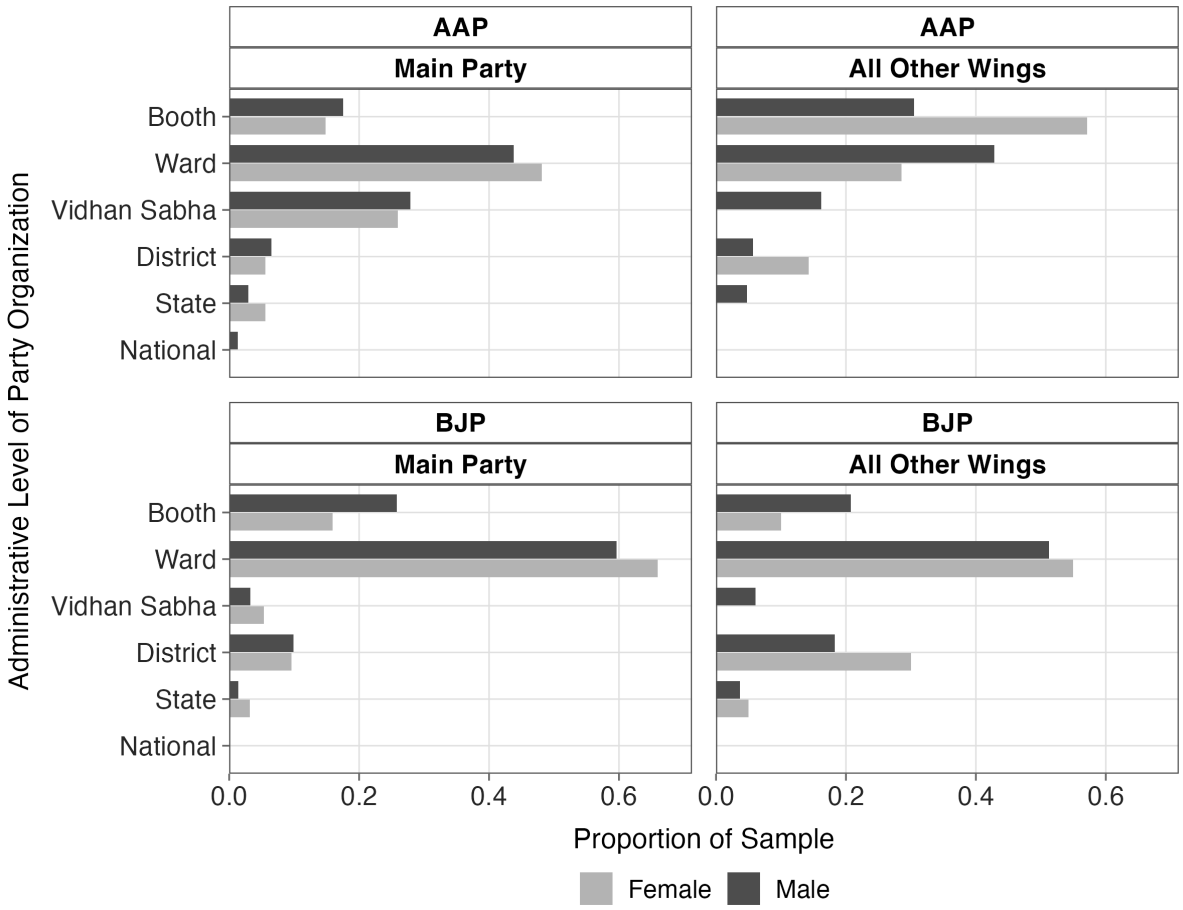


Figure SI.6: Sample Composition by Party, Gender, Administrate Levels, and Wings

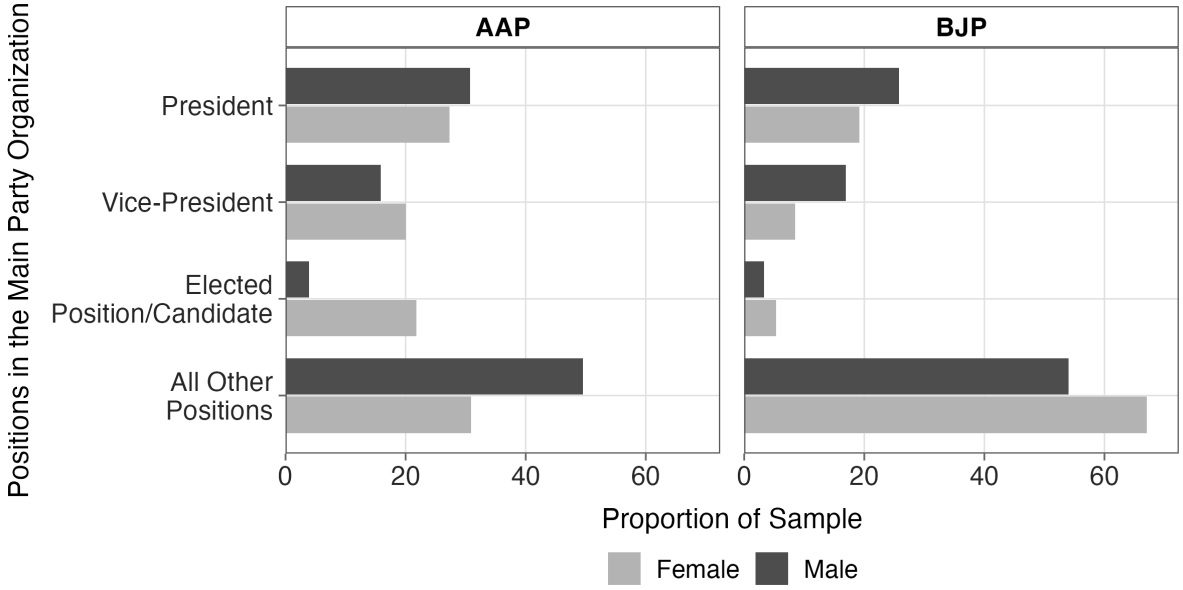


Figure SI.7: Sample Composition by Positions in the Main Party Organization and Gender

D Interviewee List

Table SI.1: Designations of Interviewees

Role / Designation	**Date**
Activist	December 26, 2023
Activist, non-profit	January 4, 2024
Activist, social movement leader	January 8, 2024
Activist, professor	January 9, 2024
Activist, politician	January 9, 2024
IAS officer, non-profit head	January 11, 2024
Political consultant, activist	January 12, 2024
Non-profit head	January 30, 2024
Residents' Welfare Association leader, retired professor	July 21, 2024
Former DU Teacher's Association leader, retired professor	July 23, 2024
Residents' Welfare Association leader, entrepreneur	July 23, 2024
Political party spokesperson	July 27, 2024
Political party youth wing leader	July 29, 2024
Activist, retired professor	July 30, 2024
Former political strategist, activist	July 31, 2024
Current Member of Legislative Assembly	August 1, 2024
Political strategist	August 3, 2024
Political strategist	August 4, 2024
Political party women's wing leader	August 5, 2024
Political party worker, non-profit head	August 5, 2024
Ex-Member of Legislative Assembly, political party worker	August 5, 2024
Lok Sabha political communications strategist	August 7, 2024
Political party spokesperson	August 13, 2024
Party worker/leader	August 13, 2024
Delhi University student politician	August 21, 2024

Table SI.1: Designations of Interviewees

Role / Designation	**Date**
Delhi University student politician	August 21, 2024
Political party state leadership	August 26, 2024
Current Rajya Sabha Member of Parliament	August 29, 2024
Activist, Ex-Student Politics, Ex-Political party worker	August 30, 2024
Media campaign strategist for political party	August 26, 2024
Ex-LAMP fellow, researcher	December 5, 2024
Ex-LAMP fellow, Member of Parliament office	December 8, 2024
Ex-LAMP fellow, Member of Parliament office	January 3, 2025
Party leader	January 7, 2025
Delhi University student	January 9, 2025
Delhi University student	January 9, 2025
Lok Sabha Member of Parliament	January 14, 2025
Political consultant, strategist	January 16, 2025
Political consultant, strategist	January 16, 2025
Political consultant	January 20, 2025
Political fellowship team	January 21, 2025
Party worker/leader	January 22, 2025
Party worker, former Municipal Corporation of Delhi councillor	January 22, 2025
Party worker/leader	January 22, 2025
Party worker/leader	January 23, 2025
Party worker/leader	January 23, 2025
Party worker/leader	January 23, 2025
Party worker	January 23, 2025
Party worker	January 23, 2025
Former political consultant	January 30, 2025
Political consultant	February 7, 2025
Political consultant	February 7, 2025

Table SI.1: Designations of Interviewees

Role / Designation	**Date**
Party worker/leader	November 15, 2025
Party worker/leader	January 23, 2026
Party worker/leader	January 26, 2026
Party worker/leader	January 26, 2026
Student politician	July 22, 2026
Student politician	July 22, 2026
Student politician	July 22, 2026
Student politician	July 22, 2026
Student politician	July 23, 2026
Student politician	July 23, 2026
Student politician	July 23, 2026
Party leader, former student politician	July 23, 2026
Municipal Corporation of Delhi councillor, party leader	July 24, 2026
Municipal Corporation of Delhi councillor	July 27, 2026
Municipal Corporation of Delhi councillor	July 27, 2026
Party worker/leader	July 29, 2026
Party worker/leader	July 29, 2026
Municipal Corporation of Delhi councillor	July 29, 2026
Municipal Corporation of Delhi councillor	July 29, 2026
Party leader, student politician	July 29, 2026
Student politician	July 29, 2026
Former party leader	July 30, 2026
Party worker	July 30, 2026
Former party leader	July 31, 2026
Party worker	August 3, 2026
Party worker	August 3, 2026
Party leader	August 3, 2026

Table SI.1: Designations of Interviewees

Role / Designation	**Date**
Former party leader	August 3, 2026
Former party leader	August 3, 2026
Former party leader	August 3, 2026
Party worker	August 4, 2026
Party leader	August 4, 2026
Party leader	August 4, 2026
Party leader	August 4, 2026
Party worker	August 5, 2026
Party worker	August 5, 2026
Party worker	August 5, 2026
Party leader	August 5, 2026
Party worker	August 6, 2026
Party worker	August 6, 2026
Party worker	August 6, 2026
Party worker	August 6, 2026
Party worker, former student politician	August 6, 2026
Municipal Corporation of Delhi councillor	August 6, 2026
Party leader	August 6, 2026
Party leader	August 6, 2026
Party leader	August 6, 2026
Party leader	August 6, 2026
Party worker	August 10, 2026
Party leader	August 10, 2026
Party leader	August 10, 2026
Party leader	August 10, 2026
Party worker	August 11, 2026
Party leader	August 11, 2026

E Organizational Roles

Table SI.2: List of Organizational Roles

No.	Role/Position
0	Election Candidate/Representative
1	President
2	Vice-President
3	In-Charge/Prabhari
4	General Secretary
5	General Secretary (Organization)
6	Secretary
7	Treasurer
8	IT and/or Social Media In-Charge
9	Office Secretary/Co Office Secretary
10	Spokesperson
11	Chief Spokesperson
12	Media In-Charge/Co In-Charge
13	Election In-Charge/Co In-Charge
14	Executive Member
15	Organisational Secretary
16	Ground-Level Workers (e.g. Panna Pramukh, Kamal Sakhi, etc.)

F Conjoint Experiment Vignette

Table SI.3 shows all the attributes and their levels presented in the conjoint. The survey had three types of randomization: (1) Order of the attributes was randomized, (2) The level of the attribute presented was randomized, and (3) The committee for which the leader was being selected was randomized between ward- and district-level. All attributes were weighted equally. The conjoint was placed after a set of demographic questions to prevent any post-treatment bias in the heterogeneous effects analysis.

Factor	**Operationalization**	**Levels**
Gender	Gender	Male (baseline) Female
Caste	Caste	General (baseline) SC OBC
Ability to establish electoral base	Mobilization power	Organized a 50 person rally in their locality (baseline) Organized a 250 person rally in their locality Organized a 400 person rally in their locality
Financial resources	Electoral campaign contribution	Less than 1 lakh (baseline) Between Rs. 1 lakh and Rs. 5 lakh Between Rs. 5 lakh and Rs. 10 lakh
Delivering Constituency Services	Ability to get work done	This candidate got (*did not get (baseline)*) the municipality to fix a broken road after residents complained This candidate got (*did not get (baseline)*) the municipality to collect trash after residents complained This candidate got (*did not get (baseline)*) the municipality to install streetlights after residents complained
Party loyalty	Party membership	Been a member of multiple parties (baseline) Been a lifelong member of your party
Party leadership experience	Highest post in the party	No post held previously (baseline) [Mandal/District] committee secretary [Mandal/District]-level Morcha President (such as Mahila Morcha, Yuva Morcha, etc.)
Party Networks	Networking ability	Got the current mandal president to speak at a rally (baseline) Got the current MLA to speak at a rally Got the current state unit president to speak at a rally

Table SI.3: Attributes for Candidate Profiles

The vignette was prefaced with the following introduction:

> "Political parties often make decisions about which party members to promote to party leadership roles, such as ward president, election in-charge, morcha secretary etc. When doing so, parties consider many different attributes about a party member that would make them a suitable leader. I will now present to you hypothetical profiles of two candidates that your party is considering promoting to the role of a [mandal/district]-committee president. The attributes of these candidates will be randomly chosen. Your task will be to choose the most suitable candidate for promotion and for appointing to different roles in the party. We will repeat this task four times.
> I will first read the profiles of each candidate out loud one by one. If you would like, you can then look over the profiles yourself. Then I will ask you to choose your preferred candidate."

The vignette was then presented in a tabular form. Respondents were read the profiles out loud first and then if they asked, were handed the tablet to review the profiles.

F.1 Variable Operationalization

Below I describe the theoretical basis for operationalization of each variable.

Gender and Caste

To assess gender bias against women politicians, I varied the gender of the prospective candidate between male and female. Given the salience of caste in Indian politics, I tested the effects of the candidate's caste on the likelihood of being chosen for promotion. The caste varied between general, Scheduled Castes (SC), and Other Backward Castes (OBC). I did not include Scheduled Tribes as a category, since they are not politically salient in Delhi. Along with a measure of caste, I created a post-hoc measure matching the hypothetical candidate's caste to the respondent's caste using the demographic data collected in the survey. This allowed me to test ethnic in-group selection effects.

Mobilization Power

Vote mobilizers are critical during electoral cycles (Chhibber and Ostermann 2014; Goyal 2024b). Recent work has shown the importance of mobilization capacity of brokers in clientelistic settings (Auerbach and Thachil 2023). I assessed the effect of mobilization power on being selected for promotion. I varied the number of individuals the hypothetical candidate was able to draw out for a rally in their neighborhood. A 50-person rally indicated low mobilization capacity, 250-person rally indicated medium mobilization

capacity, and 400-person rally indicated high mobilization capacity.

Electoral Campaign Contribution

Indian elections are the most expensive in the world and money plays a ubiquitous role in Indian politics (Bussell 2018; Vaishnav 2017). During the 2024 national election, Indian parties were estimated to have spent approximately $14.4 billion (Pradhan 2024). BJP's reported expenditure to the Election Commission of India during the 2025 Delhi state election was $6.3 million (Paliwal 2025). This included a payout of nearly $28,000 to each candidate. By a different estimate, candidates themselves funded 11 percent of their total expenses during the election (Kumar 2025). These are all likely underestimating the actual expenditure during elections. It is difficult to trace informal and unofficial campaign expenses, including illegal payments made to constituents in exchange for votes (Pradhan 2024). An individual's financial resources matter even before electoral campaigning, with widespread 'ticket-buying' during the nomination phase (Singh 2023). In this context, being able to demonstrate the ability to contribute financially to one's own electoral campaign can signal both leadership and candidate viability to the party. I varied the hypothetical candidate's contributions to an election across less than Rs. 1 lakh (low contribution), between Rs. 1 lakh and 5 lakh (medium contribution), and between Rs. 5 lakh and 10 lakh (high contribution). Given that the leadership positions posed in the vignette were at the local level, these amounts are contextually appropriate.

Ability to Deliver Services

In clientelistic settings, getting work done for constituents is critical for politicians. A senior party leader and elected politician indicated that voters care most about how their lives will improve; when they decide what party to vote for, they consider whether they will get electricity, water, and better roads.[2] Successful claim-making and service delivery on behalf of constituents makes a politician more valuable to the party since she can garner more votes and more supporters in a constituency (Auerbach and Thachil 2023; Auerbach, Thachil, and Singh 2025). To test how effective service delivery impacts a candidate's viability for promotion, I used a measure drawn from Auerbach et al. (2025). I created a

[2]Interview Subject 16, interviewed by author on August 1, 2024, in New Delhi, India.

binary variable that combined all positive instances of service delivery (getting a broken road fixed, trash collected, and streetlight installed) and all negative instances of service delivery (not getting a broken road fixed, trash collected, and streetlight installed). Doing so allowed me to test the impact of successful service delivery without it being sensitive to a particular service being delivered.

Party Membership History

Fieldwork revealed the central role of party loyalty, defined by politicians as both the time spent in a single party and the number of parties one has been a part of. In the experiment, I operationalized party loyalty in terms of the latter. The hypothetical candidate could have either been a part of multiple parties during their career or a lifelong member of the respondent's party.

Previous Roles in Party Organization

Politicians in the field repeatedly emphasized that entering the party at the grassroots level and rising up the hierarchy were both possible (democratizing party membership) and necessary to be considered for promotion and candidacy. To test whether a hypothetical candidate's previous party organization leadership experience influenced their selection, I varied the highest post she had held in the party. The candidate could either be a first-time leader (no post previously held), a committee secretary, or a committee wing president.

Networking Ability

Lastly, I assessed whether an individual's networks influenced their likelihood of selection as a party leader. As discussed in the theory section, networks are not only central to political entry, but also to advancement post-entry. To test this, I varied the post of the politician invited by the hypothetical candidate to a party rally. The post of the 'guest of honor' or the main guest at a rally can signal the quality of an individual's political network. A ward-level president indicated low networking ability, an elected state legislator indicated medium ability, and a state-committee president indicated high ability.

F.2 Estimation Strategy

In the conjoint, each respondent, i, was given k conjoint tasks ($k \in \{1, 2, 3, 4\}$), and asked to choose their candidate, j ($j \in \{1, 2\}$), with their preferred characteristics. The resulting OLS regression used to calculate the AMCE is:

$$\begin{aligned} chosen_{ijk} = &\beta_0 + \beta_1(\texttt{gender}_{ijk} = female) + \beta_2(\texttt{caste}_{ijk} = general) + \\ &\beta_3(\texttt{financial resources}_{ijk} = low) + ... + \epsilon_{ijk} \end{aligned} \tag{1}$$

In each task, whether a candidate was chosen is represented by the variable *chosen* which is a binary variable: 1 if the candidate was chosen and 0 if the candidate was not. Because each respondent performed four conjoint tasks, there are eight observations for each respondent (4 for candidates who were chosen and 4 for candidates who were not). For each attribute, the baseline is withheld (for example, for gender the variable $gender_{ijk} = male$ will be omitted). Each candidate's attribute levels are coded as dummy variables. Therefore, the AMCE for each attribute level must be understood relative to the withheld baseline.

G Descriptive Survey Measures

Table SI.4: Descriptive Survey Measures: Survey Items, Construction, and Use

Measure	Survey item(s)	Construction	Used in
First Leadership Position			
First leadership position	First leadership position held in the party, recorded by position, administrative level (booth, ward, Vidhan Sabha, district, state, national), and sub-organization (main party, women's wing, other wing).	Categorical: *main party* if the first position was in the main party organization; *women's wing* if it was in the women's wing; *wing* otherwise. Women whose first position was in a wing other than the women's wing are excluded from the main analyses, so that "women in the wing" refers only to women's wing entrants. An expanded definition including all wings is used in robustness checks.	Sociopolitical capital gaps; promotion outcomes
Promotion Outcomes			
Lateral promotion to the main party	First, current, highest, and up to nine other leadership positions, each recorded by position, administrative level, and sub-organization.	Binary; defined only for respondents whose first position was in a party wing. Takes value 1 if the respondent *ever* held a leadership position in the main party organization (in any listed position, at any level or rank), 0 otherwise.	Promotion outcomes

Continued on next page

Table SI.4 continued

Measure	Survey item(s)	Construction	Used in
Upward promotion within the starting sub-organization	Same as above.	Binary. Takes value 1 if, among later positions held in the *same* sub-organization as the first position, the respondent *ever* (i) held a position at a higher administrative level than the first position, or (ii) held an elected, President, or Vice-President position when the first position was not one of these. Positions in other sub-organizations do not count. Position promotion uses this strict definition because the hierarchy below President/Vice-President is not clearly defined.	Promotion outcomes
Electoral candidacy	"Have you ever contested an election?"	Binary. Takes value 1 if the respondent has ever contested an election at any level (student, local, state, or national), 0 otherwise.	Promotion outcomes
Pre-entry Networks			
Male recruiter	"Who encouraged you to join politics?" (male/female family member, male/female friend, male/female party leader or worker, nobody).	Binary. Takes value 1 if the respondent named a male family member, male friend, or male party leader/worker; 0 if they named a woman or nobody.	Promotion outcomes (control); pre-entry network gaps

Continued on next page

Table SI.4 continued

Measure	Survey item(s)	Construction	Used in
Family in politics	"Do you have any family in politics?"	Binary. Takes value 1 if the respondent has family in politics, 0 otherwise.	Promotion outcomes (control); pre-entry network gaps; sociopolitical capital gaps
Knew someone in politics before joining[a]	"Did you know anyone in politics before you joined?"	Binary. Takes value 1 if the respondent knew anyone in politics before joining the party, 0 otherwise.	Promotion outcomes robustness check
Family in politics and pre-entry contact[a]	Family in politics; knew someone in politics before joining.	Binary. Takes value 1 if the respondent both has family in politics and knew someone in politics before joining. Because the family item refers to the present, this excludes ties that may have formed after entry.	Promotion outcomes robustness check
Promotion Outcome Control Variables			
Years in party	"How many years have you been part of [current party]?"	Continuous (years). Measures tenure.	Promotion outcomes (control)
Caste	Self-reported caste category.	Categorical: General (reference), OBC, SC/ST. "Don't know/refused" is coded missing; these respondents drop out of adjusted models only.	Promotion outcomes (control)
Sociopolitical Capital			
Networks in the party			

Continued on next page

Table SI.4 continued

Measure	Survey item(s)	Construction	Used in
Number of people in political network	List of up to five people closest to the respondent in their political network.	Count (0–5) of network members the respondent named.	Sociopolitical capital gaps (t-test)
Most important network contact: administrative level	Administrative level of the most important person in the respondent's political network.	Binary indicator for a contact at the Vidhan Sabha, district, state, or national level (vs. booth or ward).	Sociopolitical capital gaps (χ^2 test)
Most important network contact: sub-organization	Sub-organization of the most important person in the respondent's network.	Binary indicator for a contact in the main party organization (vs. any party wing).	Sociopolitical capital gaps (χ^2 test)
Most important network contact: gender	Gender of the most important person in the respondent's network.	Binary indicator for a male contact.	Sociopolitical capital gaps (χ^2 test)
Constituency recognition			
Constituency to contest from	"Do you have a constituency (such as ward, assembly constituency, parliamentary constituency) you would want to contest an election from?"	Binary. Takes value 1 if yes, 0 otherwise.	Sociopolitical capital gaps (χ^2 test)
Constituency recognition	"In your opinion, what proportion of this constituency recognizes you?"	Continuous, rescaled to 0–1. Respondents without a constituency are coded 0.	Sociopolitical capital gaps (t-test)
Previous leadership experience			

Continued on next page

Table SI.4 continued

Measure	Survey item(s)	Construction	Used in
Leadership role in main party	Full list of leadership positions (as used in promotion outcomes).	Binary. Takes value 1 if any listed position is in the main party organization, excluding positions recorded only as party worker/member.	Sociopolitical capital gaps (χ^2 test)
Leadership role in party wing	Full list of leadership positions (as used in promotion outcomes).	Binary. Takes value 1 if any listed position is in the women's wing or another party wing, excluding positions recorded only as party worker/member.	Sociopolitical capital gaps (χ^2 test)
Number of positions held in party	Full list of leadership positions (as used in promotion outcomes).	Count of distinct positions listed (first, current, highest, and other positions); positions with identical rank, level, and sub-organization are counted once.	Sociopolitical capital gaps (t-test)

Notes: For sociopolitical capital gaps, differences between women entering through the women's wing and women entering through the main party organization are tested with two-sample tests of proportions (Pearson χ^2) for binary and categorical indicators and Welch two-sample t-tests for counts and continuous measures. Each difference and its confidence interval is divided by the standard deviation of that measure among the two groups compared, so gaps are reported in standard deviation units. Promotion outcomes are estimated with OLS and robust (HC2) standard errors, unadjusted and adjusted for pre-entry networks (male recruiter, family in politics), years in party, and caste. [a]Used only in the robustness checks in Appendix [INSERT HERE], where it replaces family in politics.

H Conjoint Results

H.1 Main Conjoint Results: Average Marginal Means

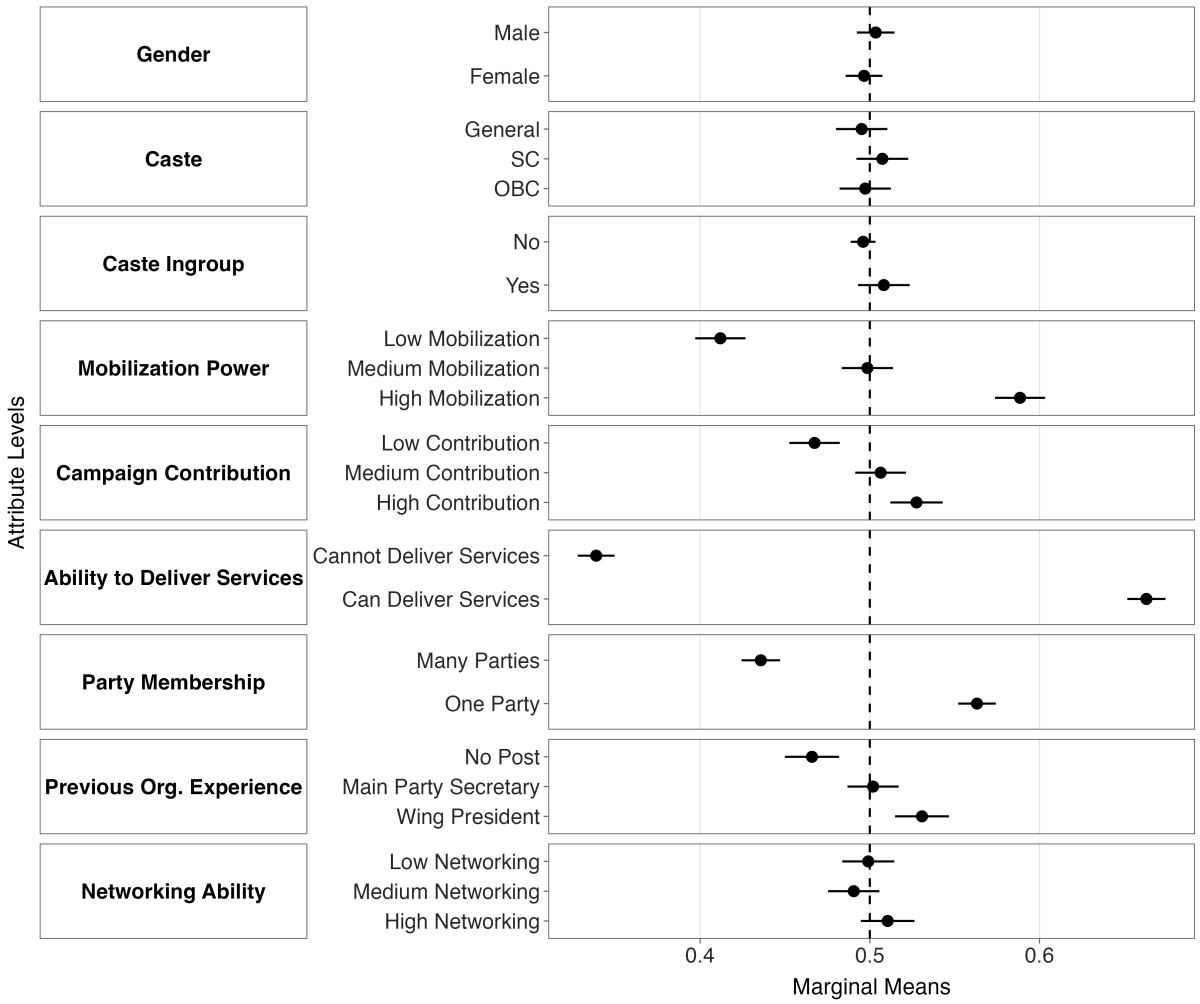


Figure SI.8: Average Marginal Means of Attributes Influencing Promotion

H.2 Outright Bias Among Male Respondents

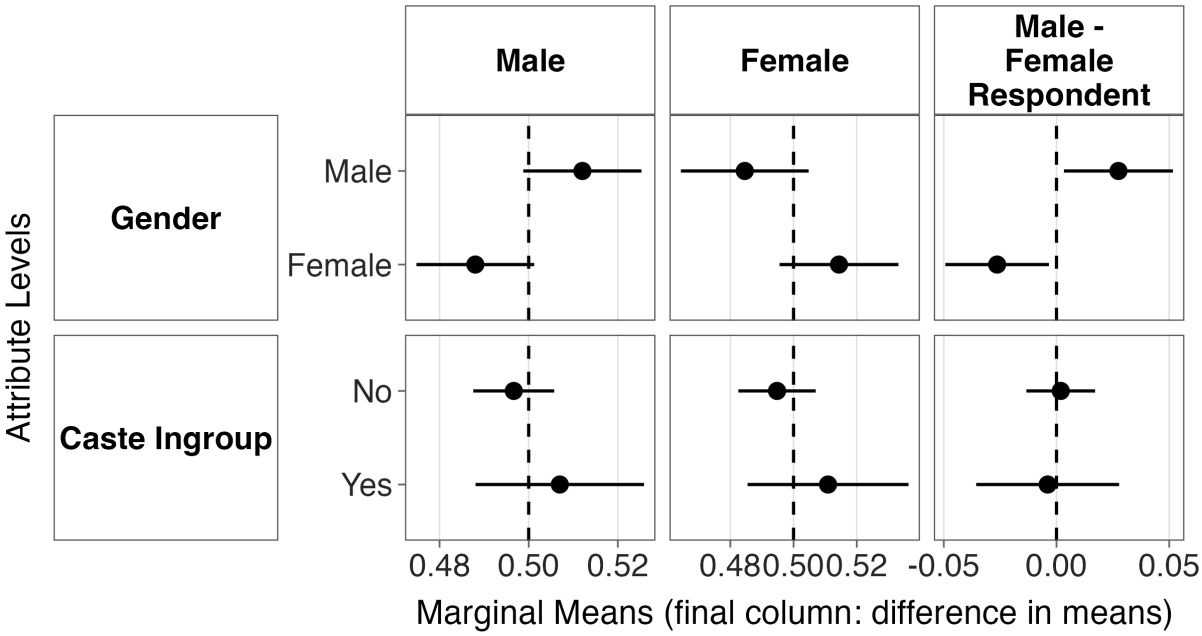


Figure SI.9: Gender Bias Among Elites

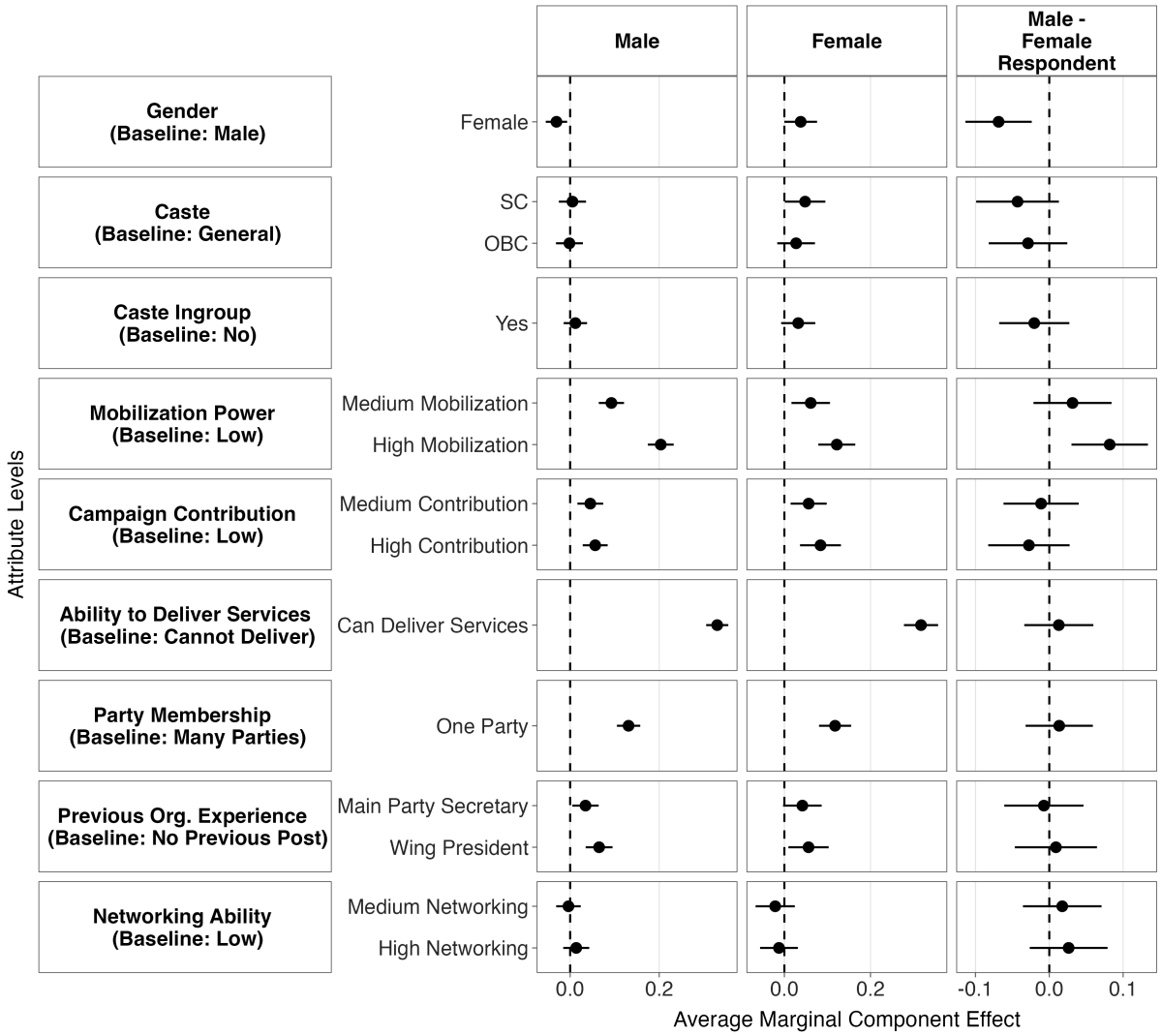


Figure SI.10: Average Marginal Component Effects and Differences in AMCEs between Male and Female Respondents

I also interacted the candidate profile's gender with all other attributes among male respondents. This tested whether female candidate profiles were adjudicated more harshly for promotion relative to male candidate profiles. While many difference in means estimates are not statistically significant, they generally lie to the left of the dashed line. This indicates that equally (un)qualified women are less likely to be considered favorably for promotion relative to men. This bias is more pronounced when both profiles are less qualified.

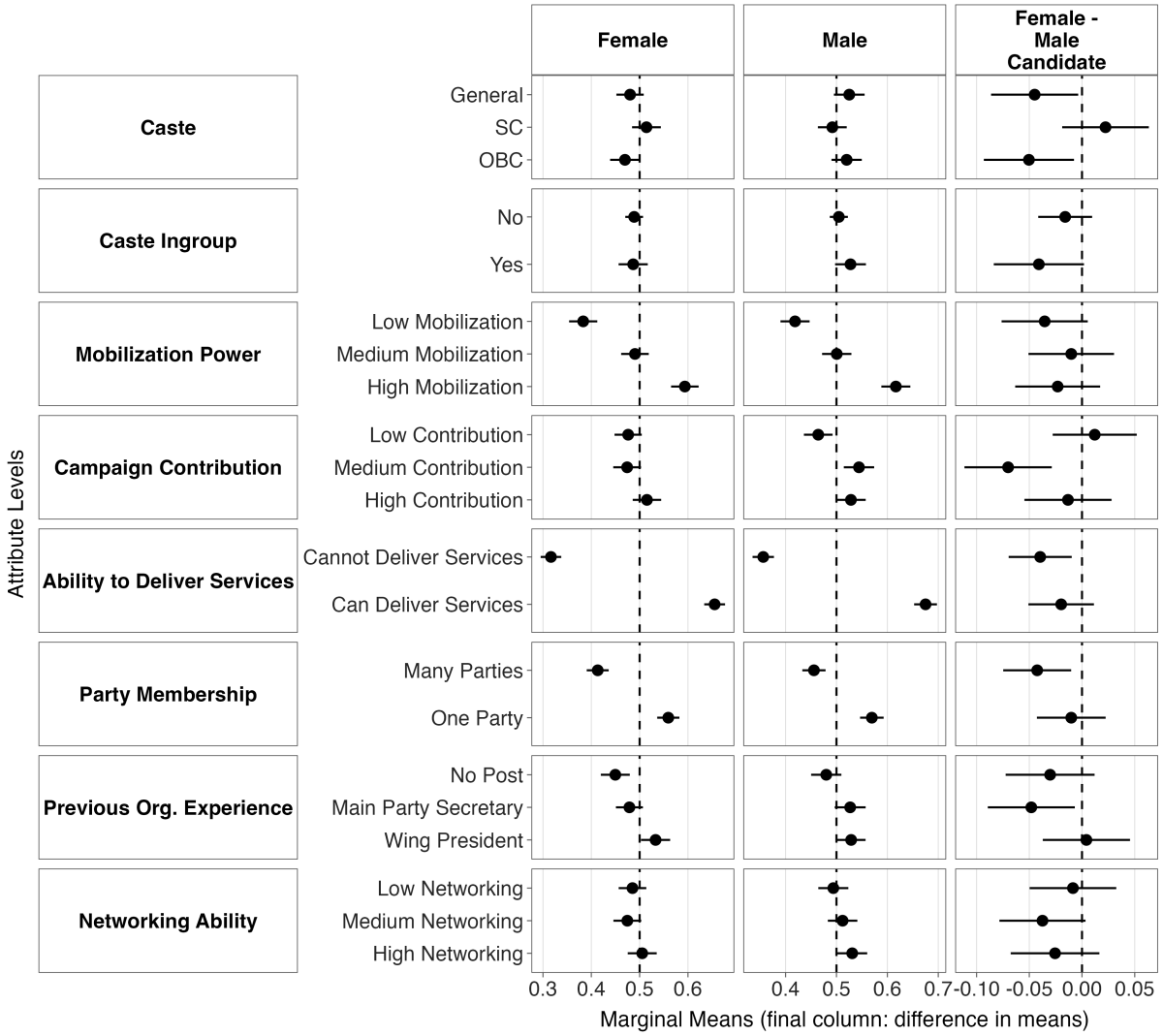


Figure SI.11: Average Marginal Means for Interaction Between Gender and All Other Attributes Among Male Respondents

H.3 Heterogeneous Effects by Respondent Party

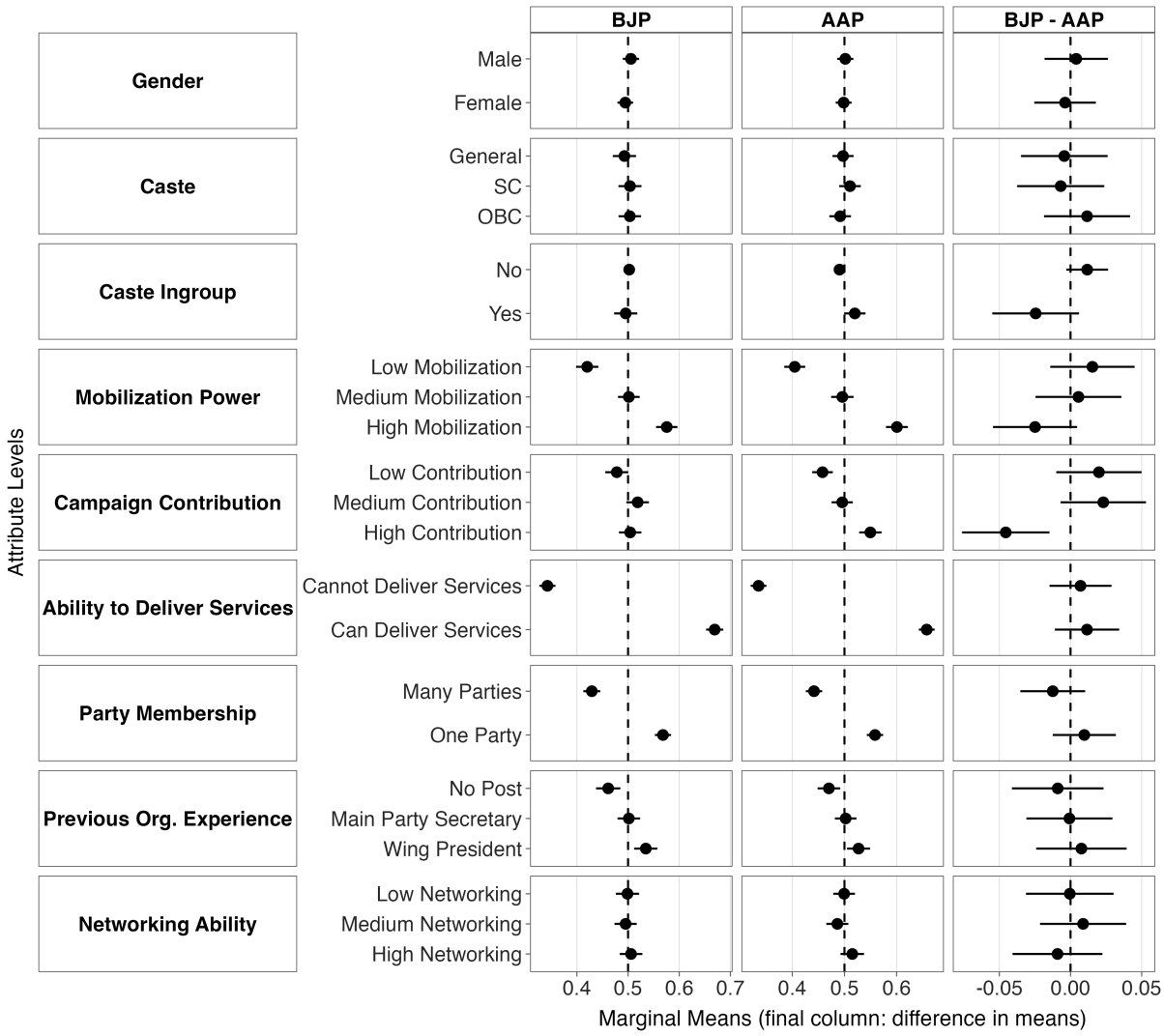


Figure SI.12: Difference in Preferences by Respondent Party

I Descriptive Results

I.1 Widening Sociopolitical Capital Gap Over Women's Tenures

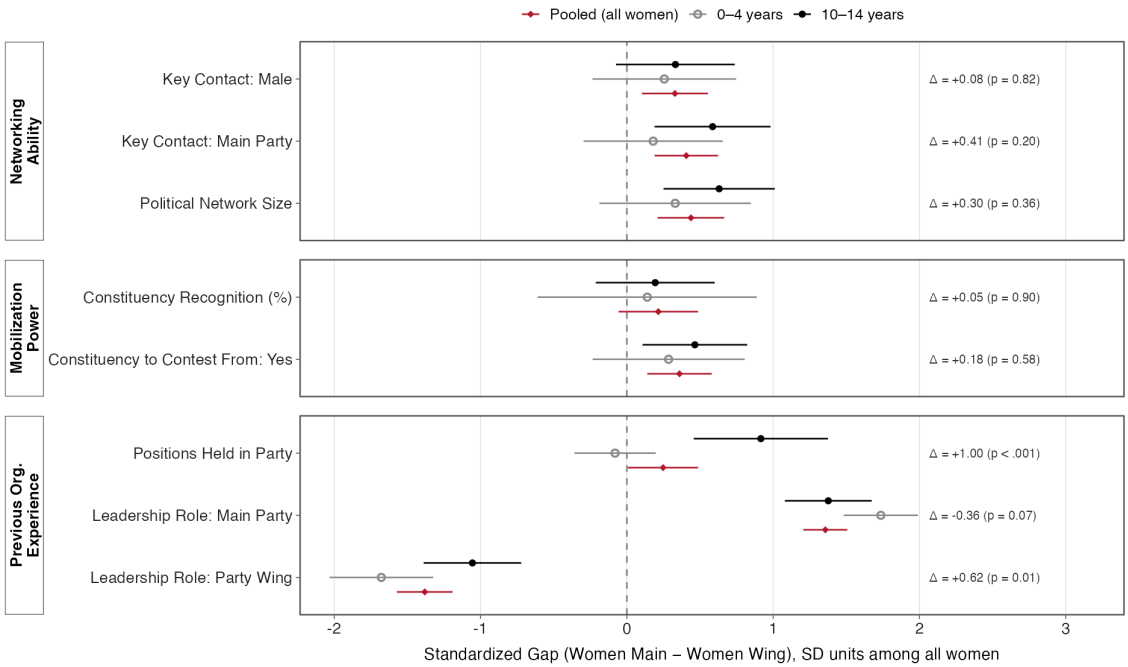


Figure SI.13: Sociopolitical Capital Gaps by Tenure in Party

Note: Points show the gap between women who entered through the main party and women who entered through the women's wing (main party − women's wing), with 95% confidence intervals. All outcomes are standardized to mean 0 and standard deviation 1 among all women in the comparison, so gaps are in standard deviation units. Gaps for women with 0–4 years (n = 64) and 10–14 years (n = 91) in the party come from the regression $Y_i = \beta_0 + \beta_1 \text{Main}_i + \beta_2 \text{Late}_i + \beta_3(\text{Main}_i \times \text{Late}_i) + \varepsilon_i$, estimated on women in those two tenure groups, where Main indicates main-party entry and Late indicates 10–14 years in the party. The gap at 0–4 years is β_1 and the gap at 10–14 years is $\beta_1 + \beta_3$. The pooled gap is the difference in means across all women regardless of tenure (n = 302). Δ is the change in the gap from 0–4 to 10–14 years (β_3), with its p-value. Binary outcomes are estimated as linear probability models; all models use HC2 robust standard errors. Sample sizes for political network size are slightly smaller (pooled n = 296; tenure groups n = 152) due to item non-response.

I.2 Sociopolitical Capital Gaps between Men and Women in Party Wings

Figures SI.14 and SI.15 show that the sociopolitical capital gaps between men and women in party wings are not as extreme as among women in the women's wing and the main party organization. Even still, men in party wings tend to have more male and main party networks and accrue more party leadership experience. That they manage to receive more promotions despite not being very different from women's wing leaders indicates that in addition to an organizational division of labor, male elite bias against women favors their gender counterparts.

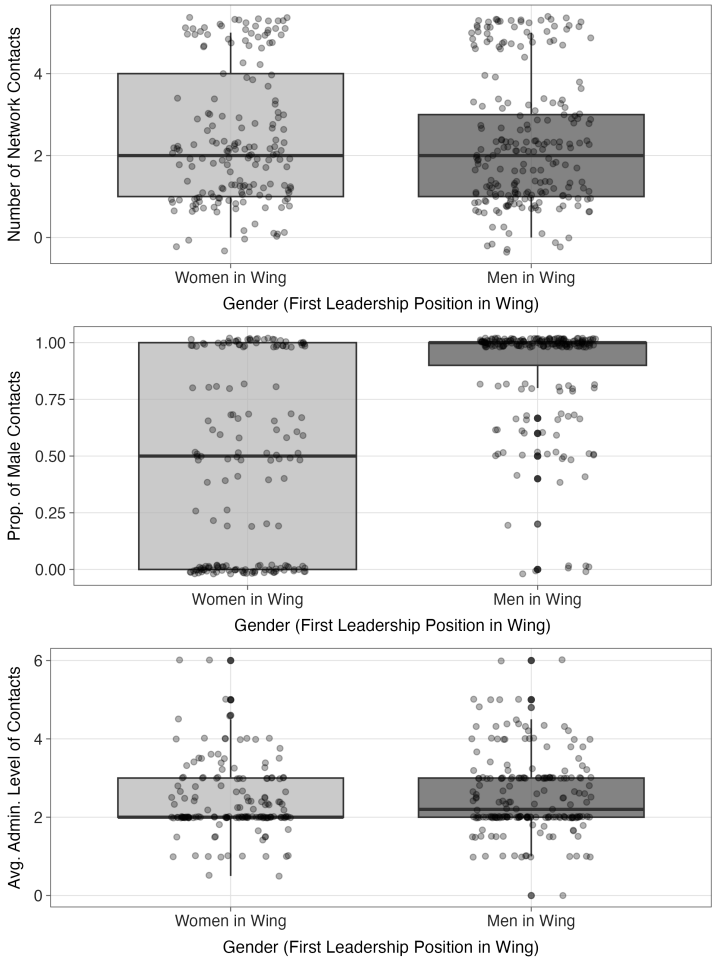


Figure SI.14: Network Differences Between Men and Women in Party Wings

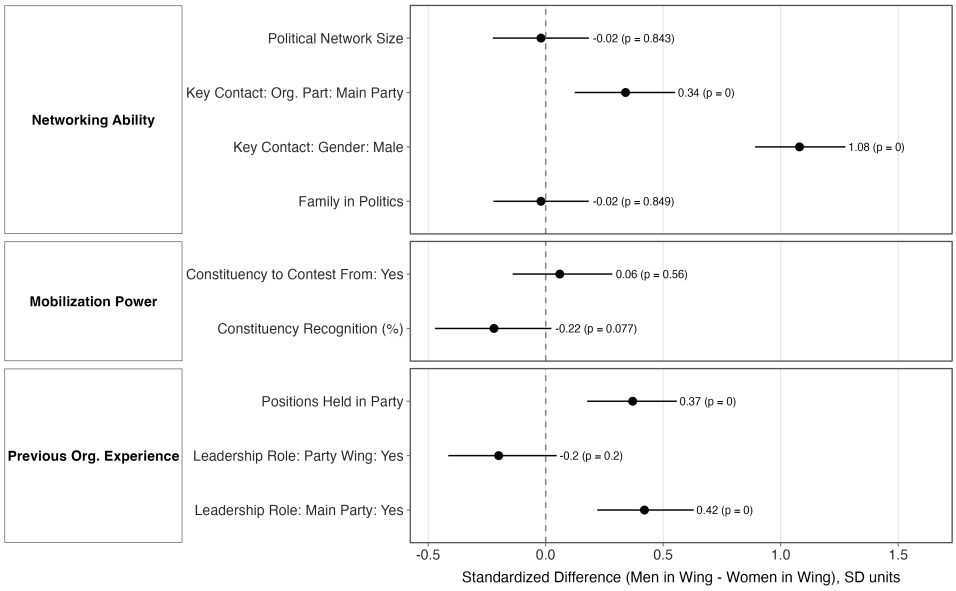


Figure SI.15: Sociopolitical Capital Gaps Between Men and Women in Party Wings

I.3 Party Work

Figure SI.16 shows the differences in the work done by the women party members who have only ever been leaders in the women's wing and those who have held at least one position in the main party organization. As the work becomes more strategic and procedural or involves more decision-making and planning, women's wing members become increasingly less involved.

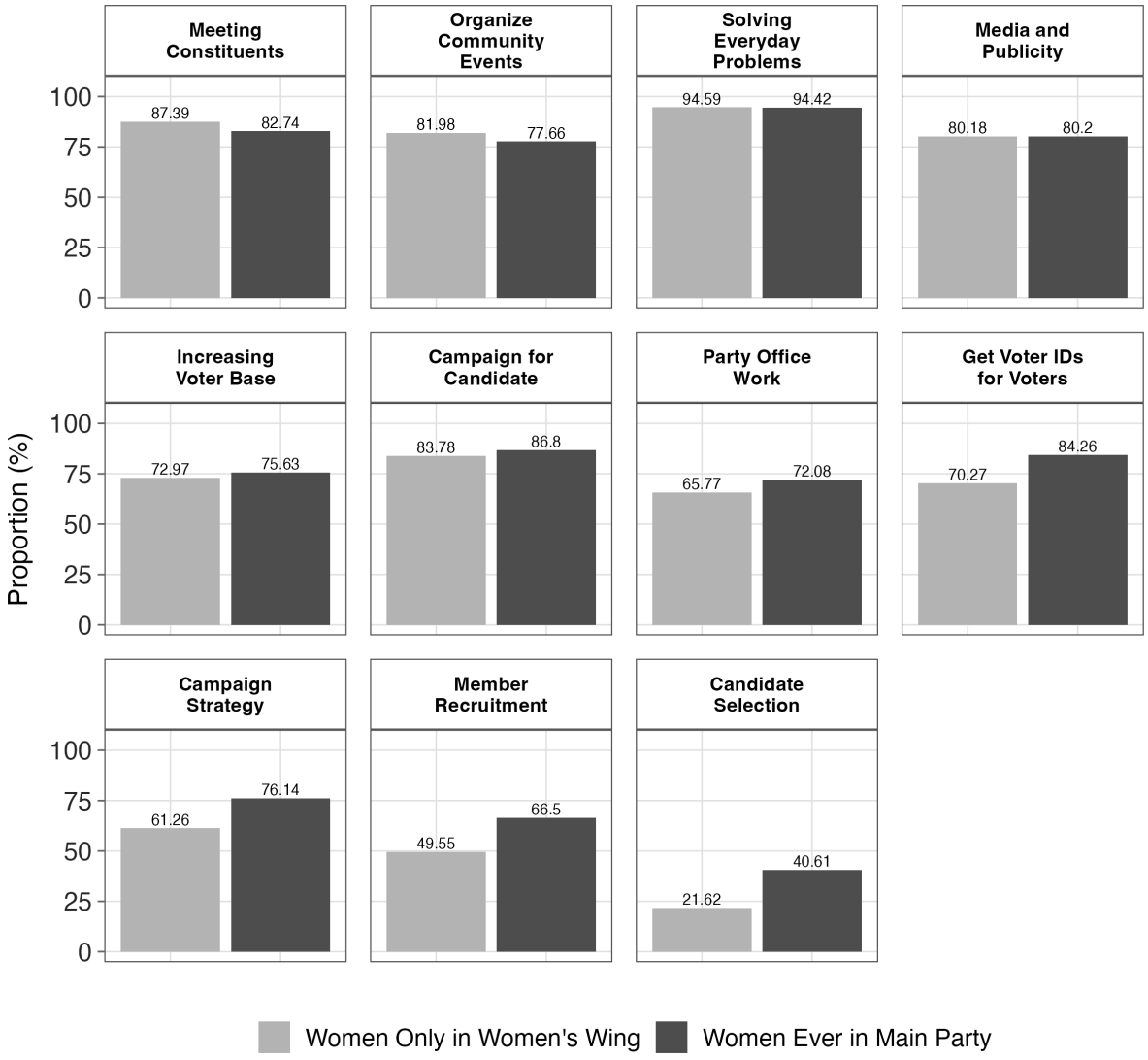
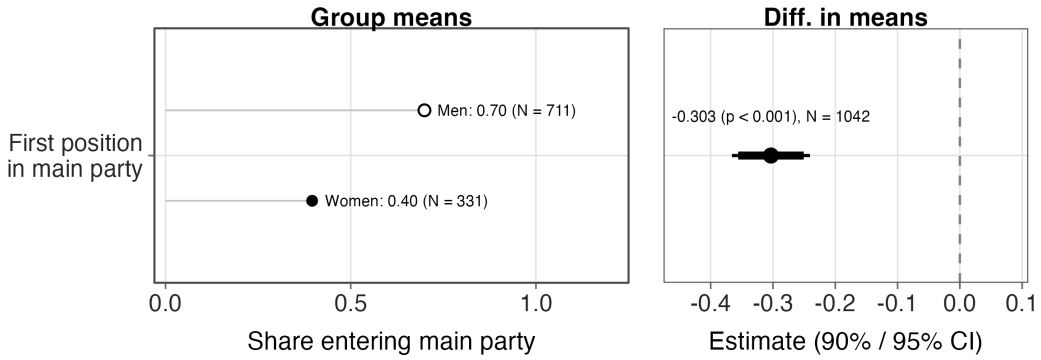


Figure SI.16: Party Work Performed by Women in the Women's Wing and Main Party Organization

I.4 Women's Wings and Political Entry

Figure SI.17 shows averages of men and women in the survey sample who stated their first leadership position in the main party organization, and the difference in means. Women respondents are 30.3 percentage points (p-value < 0.01) less likely than men to secure their first leadership role within the main party organization (Figure SI.17). Specifically, while 70 percent of men in the sample receive their first leadership position in the main party organization, only 40 percent of women do. The rest receive leadership positions in the women's wing or other party wings. Although this initial leadership role could itself reflect a promotion for a rank-and-file party worker rather than a pathway into the party, this divergence highlights deep gender segregation within the party structure and institutions where leadership roles are assigned.

Figure SI.17: Women's Party Leadership Careers Less Likely to Begin in Main Party



Note: Means of holding a main party leadership role for men (m) and women (w) on the left panel; ATE estimate (Women − Men) with 95% confidence interval on the right panel (p-value in parentheses). Models use robust standard errors.

I.5 Differences in Political Entry Networks

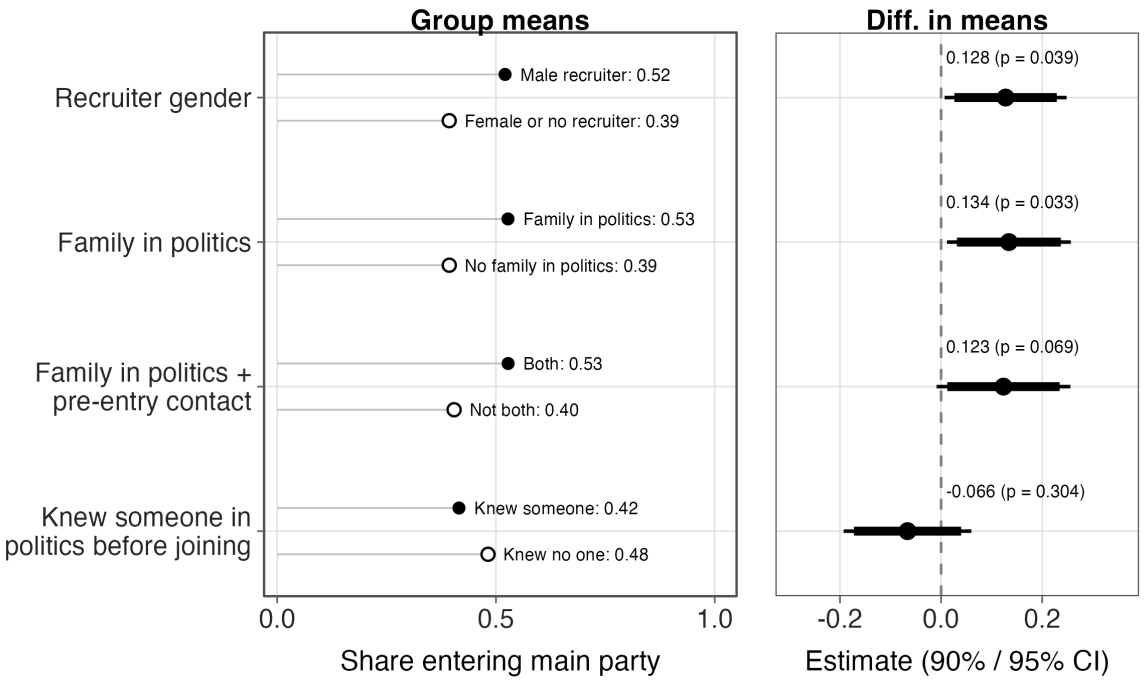


Figure SI.18: Differences in Women's Entry Networks and Predictors for First Leadership Position in Main Party

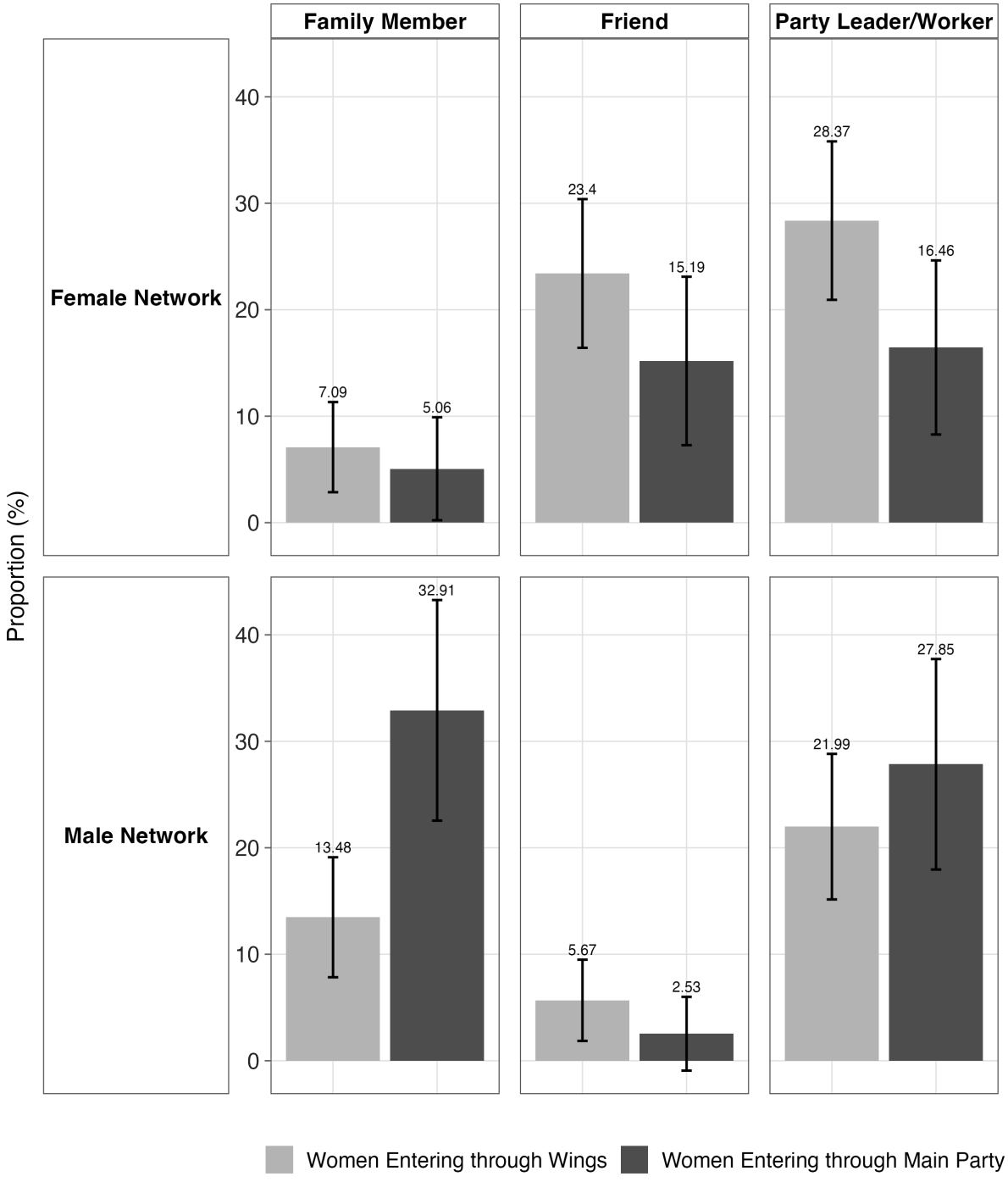


Figure SI.19: Differences in Women's Entry Networks

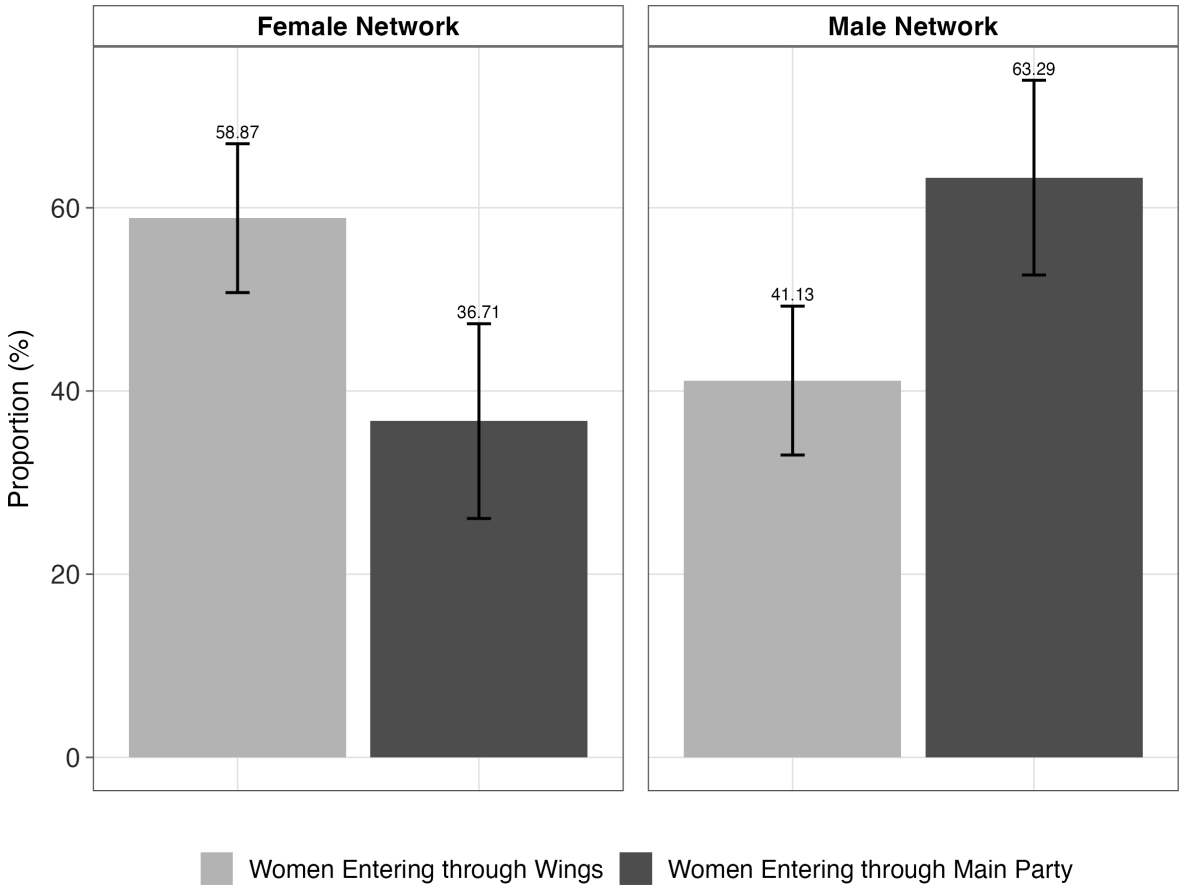


Figure SI.20: Political Entry Networks for Women in the Main Party Versus Wing

I.6 Promotion Patterns in Survey Sample

Table SI.5: Promotion outcomes by gender and sub-organization

	Men			Women			
	Main Party	Other Wings	All Men	Main Party	Women's Wing	Other Wings	All Women
Promotion to main party	–	53.3% (114)	53.3% (114)	–	32.2% (55)	37.9% (11)	33.0% (66)
Rank/position promotion within starting sub-organization	36.8% (183)	29.0% (62)	34.5% (245)	29.0% (38)	26.3% (45)	17.2% (5)	26.6% (88)
Rank/position promotion in another sub-organization	14.9% (74)	22.4% (48)	17.2% (122)	30.5% (40)	15.8% (27)	27.6% (8)	22.7% (75)
Electoral candidacy	24.7% (123)	11.7% (25)	20.8% (148)	23.7% (31)	7.0% (12)	27.6% (8)	15.4% (51)
N	497	214	711	131	171	29	331

Note: Cells show the percentage of respondents with each outcome, with counts in parentheses. Entry route is the part of the party of the respondent's first leadership position. Promotion to the main party takes value 1 if a respondent who entered through a wing ever held a main party position; it does not apply to main party entrants. Rank or position promotion takes value 1 if the respondent ever held an elected, President or Vice President rank, or a position at a higher organizational level than their first: within the part where they started, or through a position in another part of the party. A respondent can have both. Electoral candidacy takes value 1 if the respondent has ever contested an election.

Table SI.6: Promotion outcomes by gender and sub-organization: BJP

	Men			Women			
	Main Party	Other Wings	All Men	Main Party	Women's Wing	Other Wings	All Women
Promotion to main party	–	65.5% (74)	65.5% (74)	–	41.4% (48)	18.8% (3)	38.6% (51)
Rank/position promotion within starting sub-organization	37.7% (69)	30.1% (34)	34.8% (103)	29.6% (21)	25.0% (29)	25.0% (4)	26.6% (54)
Rank/position promotion in another sub-organization	21.3% (39)	30.1% (34)	24.7% (73)	35.2% (25)	21.6% (25)	18.8% (3)	26.1% (53)
Electoral candidacy	15.8% (29)	10.6% (12)	13.9% (41)	12.7% (9)	6.9% (8)	12.5% (2)	9.4% (19)
N	183	113	296	71	116	16	203

Table SI.7: Promotion outcomes by gender and sub-organization: AAP

	Men			Women			
	Main Party	Other Wings	All Men	Main Party	Women's Wing	Other Wings	All Women
Promotion to main party	–	39.6% (40)	39.6% (40)	–	12.7% (7)	61.5% (8)	22.1% (15)
Rank/position promotion within starting sub-organization	36.3% (114)	27.7% (28)	34.2% (142)	28.3% (17)	29.1% (16)	7.7% (1)	26.6% (34)
Rank/position promotion in another sub-organization	11.1% (35)	13.9% (14)	11.8% (49)	25.0% (15)	3.6% (2)	38.5% (5)	17.2% (22)
Electoral candidacy	29.9% (94)	12.9% (13)	25.8% (107)	36.7% (22)	7.3% (4)	46.2% (6)	25.0% (32)
N	314	101	415	60	55	13	128

I.7 Political Ambition Among Respondents

Figure SI.21: Political Ambition Among Survey Respondents

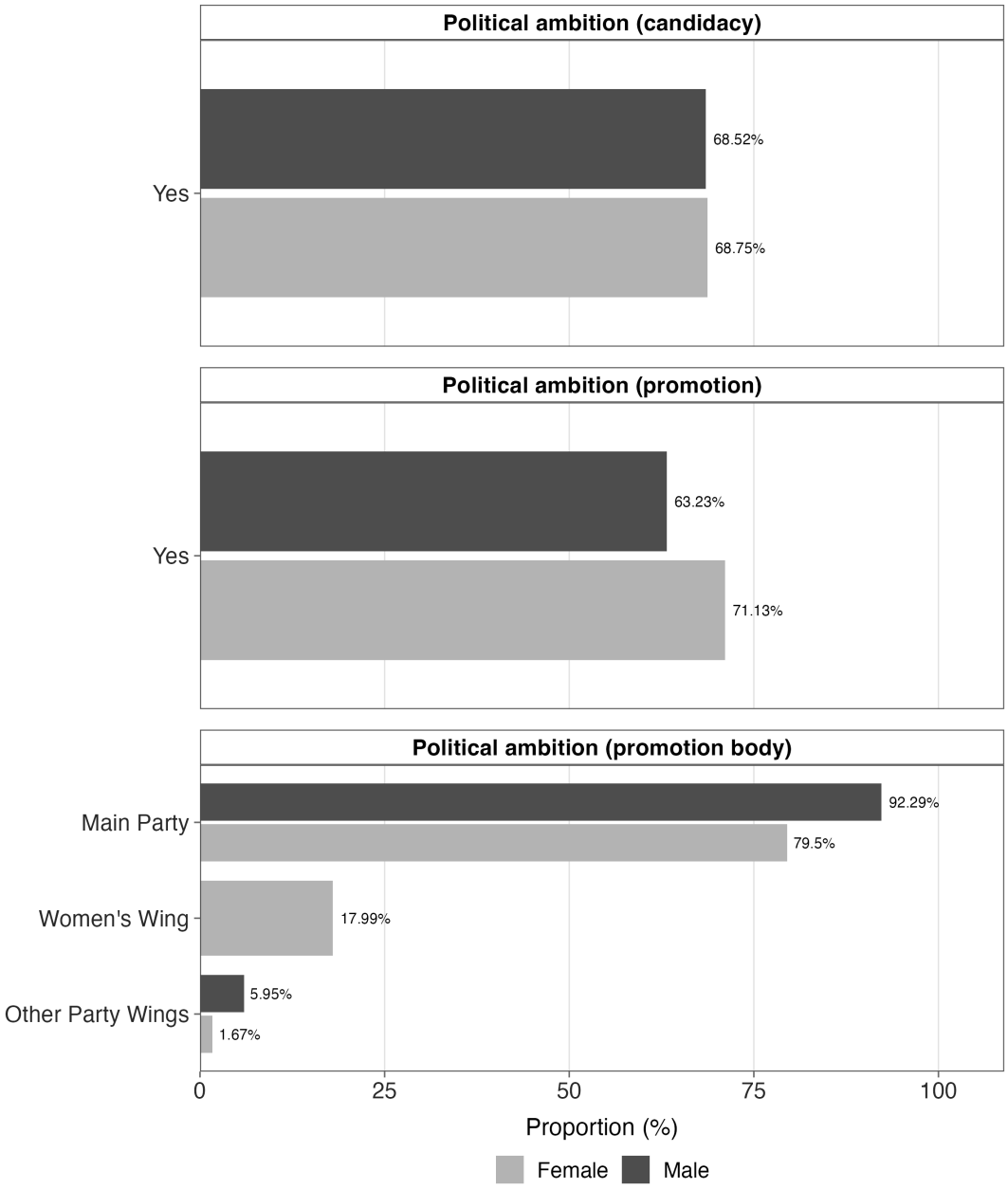


Figure SI.21 shows equal or higher rates of political ambition for electoral candidacy and promotion among male and female respondents in the survey sample. Among politically ambitious women, nearly 80 percent express ambition to be promoted into the main party organization as opposed to any other party wing. Disaggregated by where their partisan leadership careers began, 62.5 percent of women's wing members expressed ambition for candidacy (relative to 77 percent of main party women) and 67.5 percent

for promotions in party leadership (relative to 78 percent of main party women). Of these politically ambitious women, 74 percent hoped for promotions into the main party organization (relative to 88 percent of politically ambitious main party women). Figure SI.22 further disaggregates political ambition by the sub-organization where respondents began their partisan leadership career and shows consistent results.

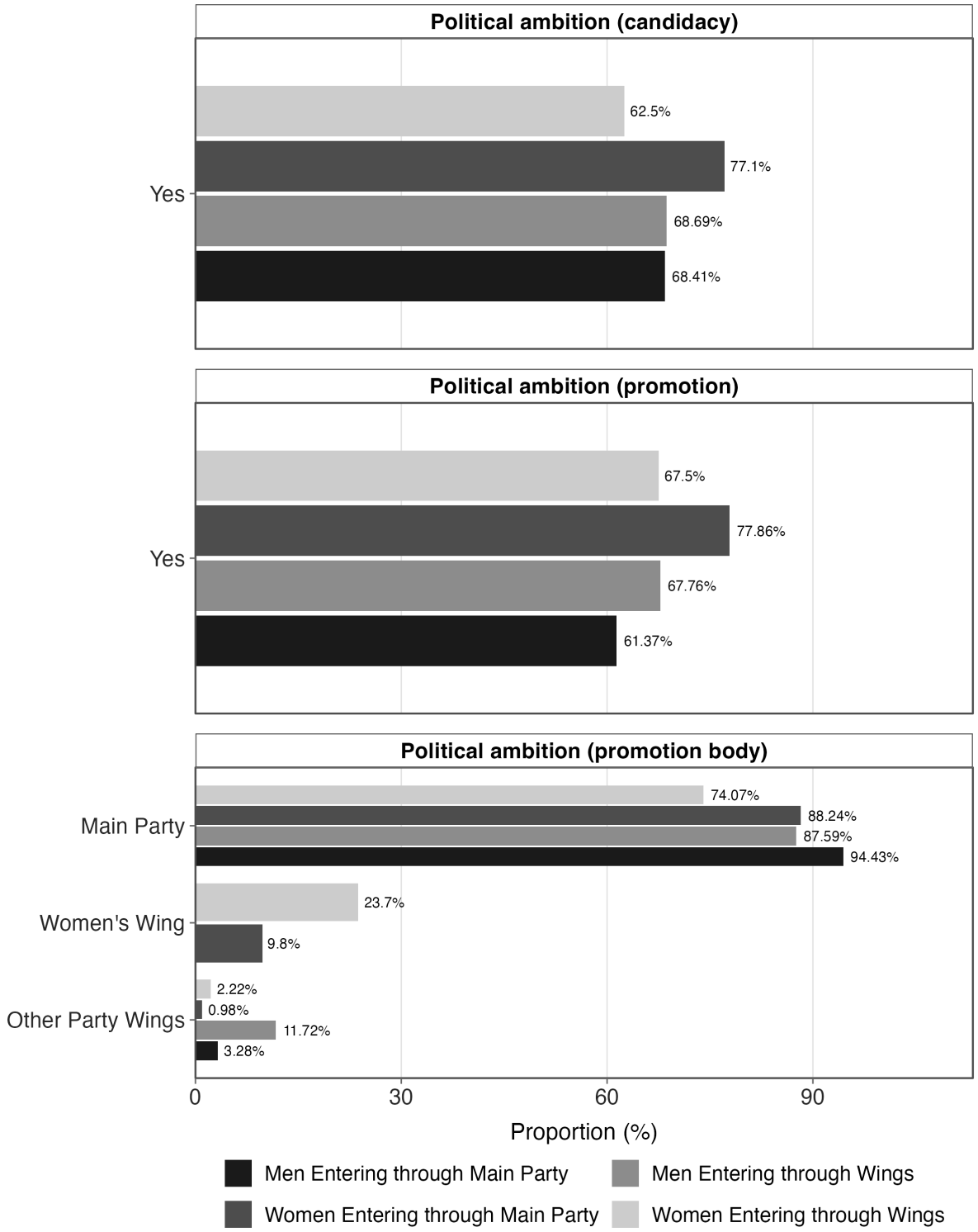


Figure SI.22: Political Ambition by Party Organization

J Robustness Checks

J.1 Alternative Specification for Pre-Entry Networks

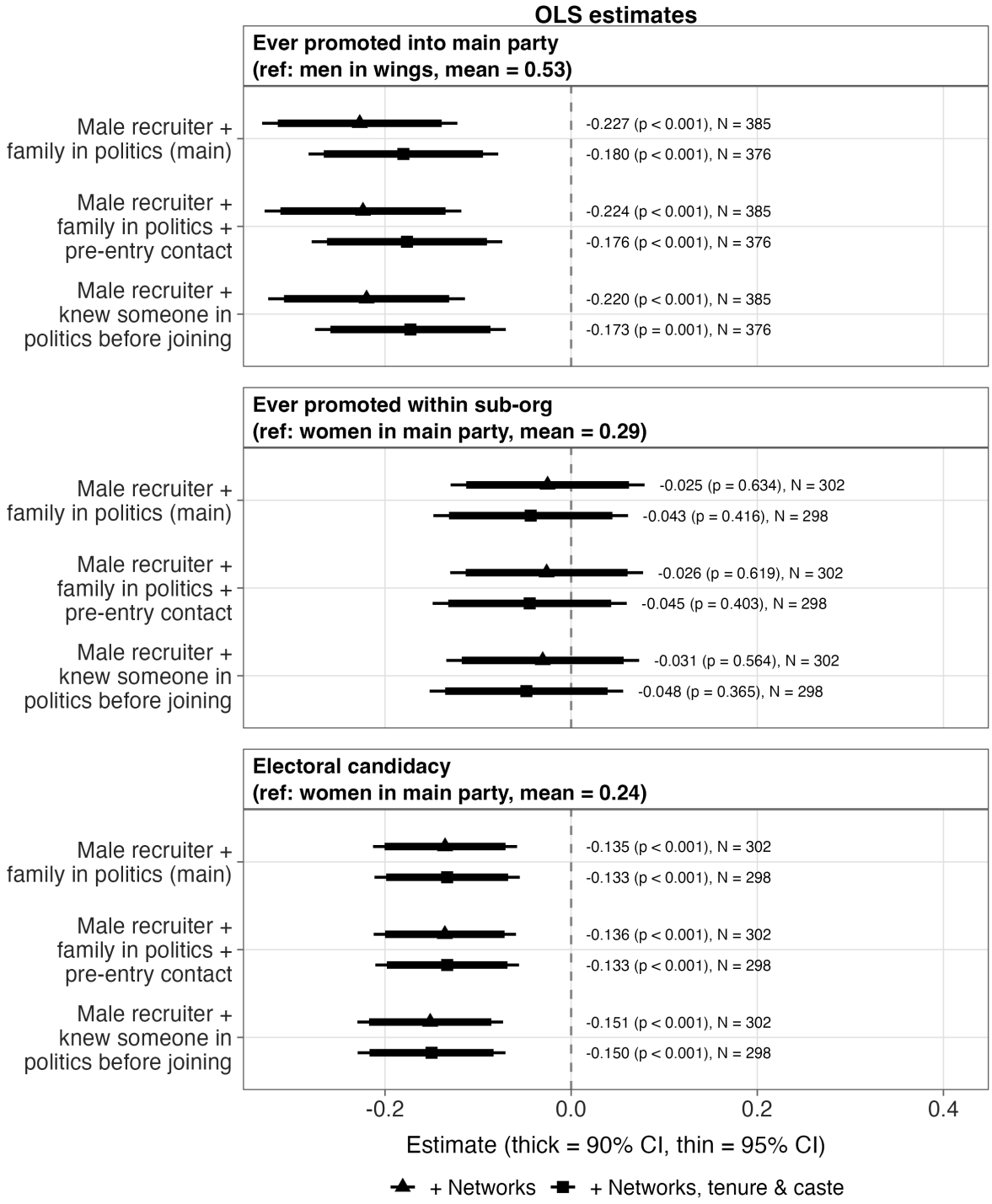


Figure SI.23: Promotion Outcomes With Alternative Pre-Entry Network Measures

Note: The figure re-estimates the promotion outcomes from the main analysis using alternative measures of pre-entry networks. The original measure captures whether the respondent had family in politics and the person who encouraged them to join was male. All regressions keep male recruiter as one pre-entry network measure. The alternative measures replace whether the respondent had family in politics and are a) whether they had family in politics *and* knew someone before joining and b) whether they knew someone before joining. Lines with triangles control only for pre-entry networks. Lines with squares also control for tenure in the party and caste. Points are estimated coefficients from OLS regressions and bars show 90% and 95% confidence intervals. The results are substantively unchanged across specifications, which suggests the main findings do not depend on how pre-entry networks are measured.

J.2 Alternative Specification for Women in Any Party Wing

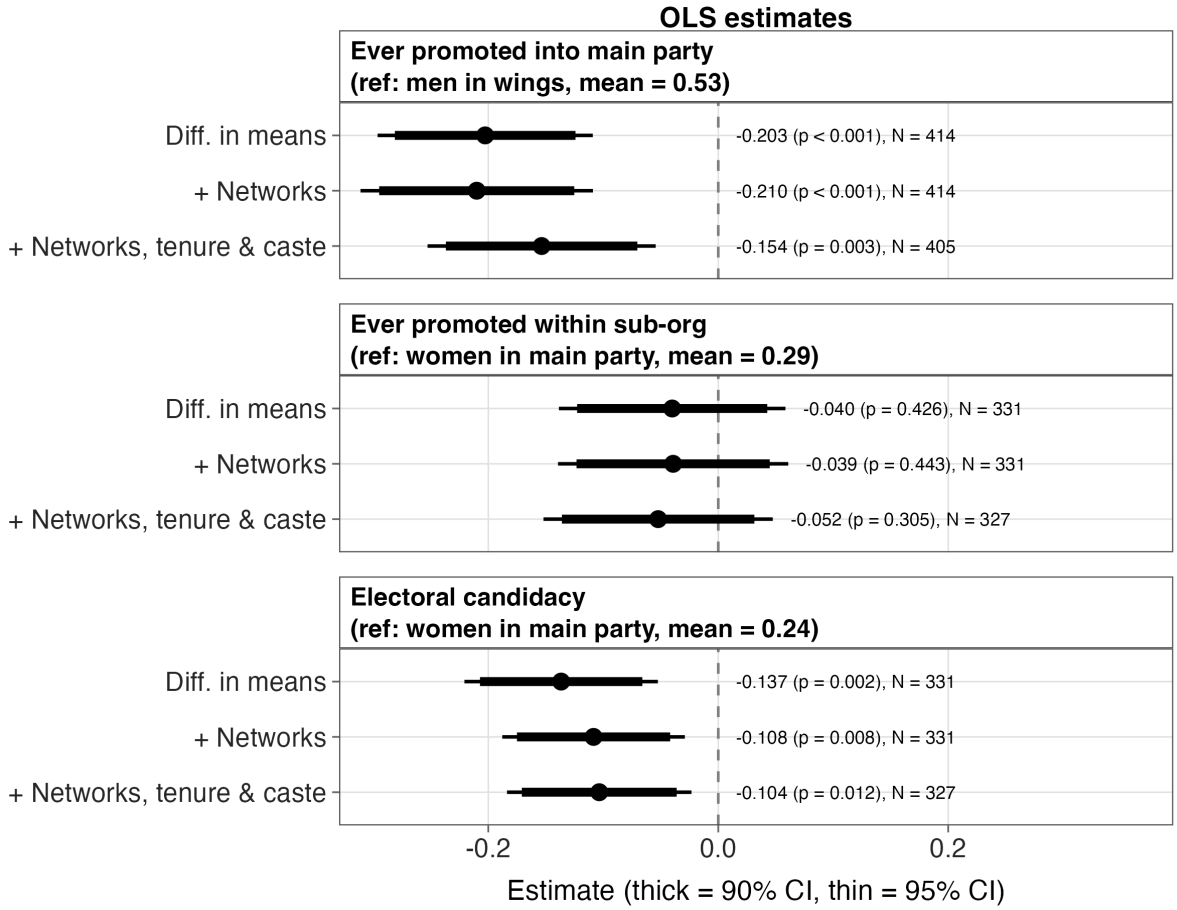


Figure SI.24: Promotion Outcomes for Women in Any Party Wing

Note: The figure re-estimates the promotion outcomes from the main analysis with a broader definition of wing membership. In the main analysis, the wing measure covers only women whose leadership careers started in the women's wing. Here it covers women whose careers began in any party wing (e.g., the women's wing, youth wing, SC/ST/OBC wings, etc.). Points are estimated coefficients from OLS regressions and bars show 90% and 95% confidence intervals. The pattern holds under this broader definition, which indicates that the penalty is common to wing-based leadership more generally, though estimates are larger when restricted to women's wings in the main analysis. A very small sample of women began their leadership careers in party wings other than women's wings.

J.3 Promotion Outcomes Disaggregated by Caste

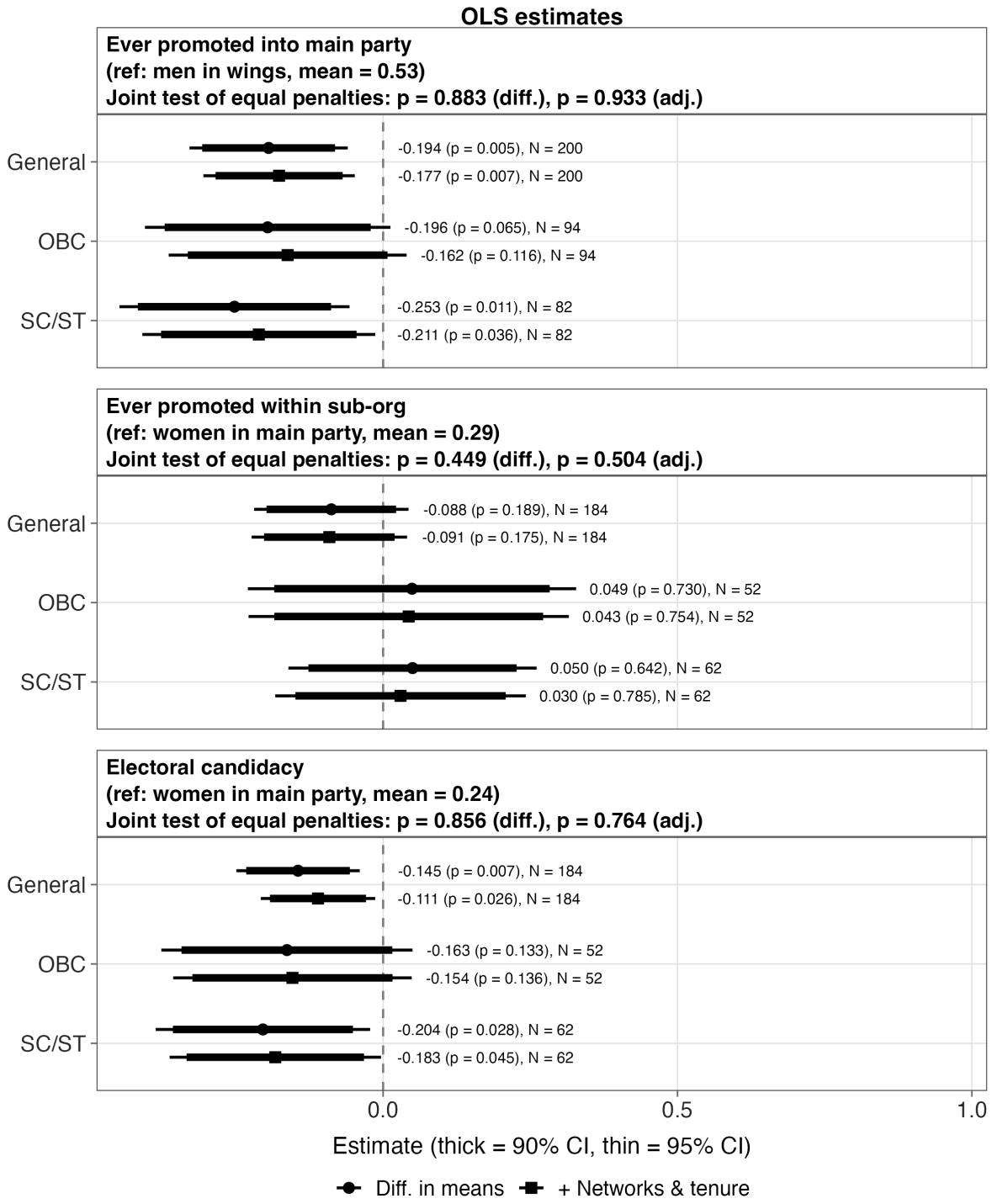


Figure SI.25: Promotion Outcomes Disaggregated by Caste

Note: The figure presents promotion outcomes separately for each caste group: General, OBC, SC/ST. The models are the same as in the main analysis, except that each is estimated within a single caste group. Points are estimated coefficients from OLS regressions and bars show 90% and 95% confidence intervals. The penalty for starting her leadership career in a women's wing appears across caste groups, which suggests the main result is not driven by the caste composition of the wings.